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Loudoun County School Board, 4th Tuesday School Board Meeting (Moved due to Rosh Hashanah), Tuesday, September 30, 2025

Date Tuesday, September 30, 2025
Place Loudoun County Public Schools / School Board meeting (see BoardDocs / LCPS-TV)
Length 5h 9m (video)

- Official meeting video (Vimeo / LCPS-TV): <https://player.vimeo.com/video/1123768746?rel=0>
- BoardDocs (School Board): <https://go.boarddocs.com/vsba/loudoun/Board.nsf/goto?open&id=DKYJGJ4D1FDE>

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-10. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:00:06] I call to order the September 30th, 2025 Loudoun County School Board meeting. I have been notified that Dr. Deans would like to remotely participate in tonight's school board meeting. Dr. Deans, please state your location and whether this is a medical or personal matter.

[00:00:26] It's medical. I'm at home in my home office. Is anyone present with you at this location? If so, please state their name. My husband is upstairs. I'll now entertain a motion for Dr. Deans' request to participate remotely.

[00:00:46] Yes, Ms. Chandler. I move that we allow Dr. Deans to participate remotely. I have a motion by Ms. Chandler. Do I have a second? Second. I have a second by Ms. Lavelle. It's been properly moved and seconded, and we will now go ahead and vote.

[00:01:04] Hold on one second. Clerk, would you please open the vote? Oh, is there any discussion? Sorry. No discussion. Clerk, would you please open the vote? board members please record your vote clerk please close and display the vote and that motion passes with dr. deans absent for the vote and vice chair donahue absent for the vote welcome to the meeting dr. deans

[00:01:40] well now we'll now move on to item agenda item two approval of the consent agenda board members are there any changes to be made to the consent agenda yes mrs griffiths thank you madam chair i would like to move item 2.16 2.16 to action thank you Okay, we will be moving, clerk, would you please move item 2.6 to action item 10.01, 2.16,

[00:02:13] sorry, to item 10.01, and then move everything else down, please. Thank you. Okay, before we vote on the consent agenda, we have five proclamations to read. The first one recognizes October 2025 as Bullying Prevention Month and will be read by Ms. Chernoff. Ms. Chernoff. Thank you Madam Chair.

[00:02:37] Bullying Prevention Month October 2025. Whereas school bullying has become an increasingly significant problem in the United States and Virginia with one out of every five students 19.2 percent in the United States estimated to be involved in bullying each year either as a bully or as a victim and whereas students who experience bullying are at increased risk of depression, anxiety, sleep difficulties, lower academic achievement, and dropping out of school.

[00:03:04] And whereas bullying can take many forms, including verbal, physical, and online, and can happen in many places on and off school grounds. And whereas it is important for parents, students, and teachers, and school administrators to be aware of bullying and to encourage discussion of the problem as a school community.

[00:03:21] And whereas the Loudoun County School Board is committed to providing for an equitable, safe, and inclusive learning and working environment, and affirms a commitment to this principle for all persons, regardless of race, color, national origin, religion, sex, pregnancy, childbirth, or related medical conditions, sexual orientation, gender identity, marital status, disability, age, genetic information, or veteran status, and whereas LCPS has adopted policy on bullying prevention and education to encourage positive behaviors and to maintain a safe and affirming school environment where every student feels safe, affirmed, and cared for and to eliminate bullying behaviors.

[00:04:00] Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board formally recognizes October 2025 as Bullying Prevention Month with the intention that the issue of bullying and its prevention be discussed in all Loudoun County public schools and classrooms to help ensure that students have a trusted adult they can turn to and to foster a sense of belonging for all students.

[00:04:22] Thank you, Ms. Chernoff. The next proclamation recognizes October 2025 as Disability History and Awareness Month and will be read by Ms. LaBelle. Ms. LaBelle. Thank you, Madam Chair. Whereas the Virginia General Assembly passed Senate Joint Resolution 321 in 2009, designating October as Disability History and Awareness Month in the Commonwealth of Virginia, and whereas the General Assembly recognized the importance of increasing public awareness and respect for people with disabilities, informing the public about the many contributions

[00:04:57] to society made by people with disabilities, and emphasizing the abilities of people with disabilities, and whereas the Americans with Disabilities Act of 1990 was enacted to end disability-based discrimination and promote inclusion, full participation, economic self-sufficiency, and equality of opportunity for all people with disabilities, and whereas Loudoun families include one or more family members with a disability who meaningfully contribute to and enrich the lives of their family members, as well as the Loudoun community, and whereas

[00:05:34] in 25-26 school year, Loudoun County Public Schools is serving approximately 10,423 students with disabilities under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act, and whereas Loudoun County Public School teachers, related service providers, administrators, and staff are working collaboratively using effective teaching approaches and related educational intervention strategies to support the unique learning needs of all students with disabilities, and whereas research has shown that students with disabilities encounter more difficulty being

[00:06:10] accepted by their peers compared to students without disabilities, and whereas in Loudoun County Public Schools more than 74.68% of students with disabilities spend more than 80% of their time in general education setting where inclusive practices are promoted, and whereas an individual educational plan or IEP is an important blueprint for all school educators and leaders includes the expectation that students with disabilities pursue high academic

[00:06:46] standards which is reduced by the great by greater than 95 percent of students with disabilities graduating on time and more than eighty four point eight percent of the students continuing to gain on to gainful employment college or other post-secondary educational opportunities during the 24/25 school year, and whereas all Loudoun County Public Schools students with disabilities need, deserve, and have potential to excel by receiving support, understanding, acceptance, and being meaningfully

[00:07:21] included in the life of their school community, and whereas Disability History and Awareness Month is an opportunity to acknowledge educators specializing in their effective teaching strategies and to celebrate the perseverance and many achievements of adolescents, students, and adults with disabilities.

[00:07:40] Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County Public School Board does hereby proclaim the month of October 2025 as the Disability History and Awareness Month and resolve to support increased appreciation, respect, and inclusion for people with disabilities and be it further resolved that Loudoun County Public School supports informing the school community and the public concerning the many valuable contributions to the school environment and society made by people with disabilities and yet further

[00:08:14] resolve that Loudoun County Public Schools principals, administrators and educators are encouraged through education and other appropriate activities, programs and events to promote and highlight the Disability History and Awareness Month in the Commonwealth of Virginia as well as the value that people with disabilities bring to their specific schools and communities, and in witness thereof, that a copy of this resolution will be sent to each Loudoun County public school so that it may be discussed, shared, and prominently displayed online and

[00:08:50] in the school during the month of October, so that the principals, administrators, and educators may plan disability awareness activities to increase inclusion and acceptance of students with disabilities throughout all of Loudoun County Public Schools resolved finally that a copy of this resolution will be sent to each Loudoun County Public School so that it may be discussed shared and prominently display displayed online and in the school during the month of October so that principals administrators and educators may plan disability awareness

[00:09:27] activities to increase inclusion acceptance of students with disabilities throughout all of LCPS. Thank you, Ms. LaBelle. Our third proclamation recognizes October 2025 is Domestic and Dating Violence Awareness Month and will be read by Vice Chair Donohue. Vice Chair.

[00:09:47] Thank you, Madam Chair. Whereas October is Domestic and Dating Violence Awareness Month and calls attention to the fact that dating and domestic violence are widespread and their effects impact our community and whereas domestic violence affects one in three women and one in four men in their lifetime. In addition, one in 12 high school students has experienced violence in a dating relationship. Domestic violence and dating relationship violence causes harm to thousands of Virginians, regardless of their age, race, sexual orientation, religion, gender identity, or socioeconomic status. And whereas during Domestic and Dating Violence Awareness Month,

[00:10:26] we honor survivors and provide public awareness on this violation of the basic human right to be free from violence and abuse, removing the stigma and shame surrounding such violence, expanding support for survivors of sexual violence, and strengthening our response, and whereas, although progress has been made toward preventing and ending domestic and dating violence, and providing support to survivors and their families, important work remains to be done.

[00:10:51] In particular, a focus on teaching the community about healthy relationships to help reduce the likelihood of dating partner violence. And whereas Loudoun County Public Schools and Law's Domestic Violence and Sexual Assault Services work together to name the current challenges to addressing violence, identify strategies to address risk factors, and implement solutions to stop violence before it happens. And whereas recognizing that the trauma sustained from experiencing domestic or dating relationship violence is not something that someone gets over, it is something that someone survives, Loudoun County Public Schools is committed to raising awareness about

[00:11:27] healthy relationships and body safety, taking ownership in prevention work, and creating a culture where violence is unacceptable. Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board formally recognizes October 2025 as Domestic and Dating Violence Awareness Month, a time in our community to create safety for children, youth, faculty, staff, and families in Loudoun County Public Schools. Working together, we encourage our community to share information about domestic and dating violence prevention, support survivors, and speak out against harmful attitudes and actions, joining advocates and communities across the Commonwealth and the

[00:12:02] country in playing an active role to prevent domestic and dating violence. Thank you, Vice Chair Donohue. And our fourth proclamation recognizes October 2025 is Dyslexia Awareness Month and will be read by me. Whereas dyslexia is a specific learning disability related to a deficit in the phonological component of language is neurobiological in origin and is characterized by challenges in word recognition, writing, spelling, and processing of written language

[00:12:36] that may result in deficits in reading comprehension and vocabulary. And whereas dyslexia is the most common learning disability in children and persists throughout life, affecting one of every five people regardless of ability, race, gender, age, or socioeconomic status. And whereas early screening for and early identification of dyslexia is critical to ensure that individuals with dyslexia receive focused, evidence-based intervention grounded in science-based reading research that leads to fluent reading, the promotion of self-awareness and self-advocacy,

[00:13:14] and the provision of necessary accommodations to build success in school and life. And whereas many successful people, notably in business, government, sports, and entertainment, have overcome difficulties related to dyslexia.

[00:13:31] And whereas raising awareness about dyslexia and promoting a greater understanding of the strengths and challenges associated with this learning difference can help create a more inclusive and supportive environment for individuals with dyslexia. And whereas the Commonwealth of Virginia through the Virginia Literacy Act has regulations and programs in place to help children and improve the lives of individuals with dyslexia, including intervention, screening, and service requirements. And whereas Dyslexia Awareness Month is an opportunity to acknowledge educators specializing in effective teaching strategies and to celebrate

[00:14:10] the many achievements of adolescents, students, and adults with dyslexia. And whereas Loudoun County Public Schools recognizes that reading is a gateway to other skills by creating opportunities for individuals to pursue higher education, get good jobs, and become full participants in our democracy, and now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board formally recognizes October 2025 as Dyslexia Awareness Month and commends this observance to all our students, staff, and families to promote greater awareness, use effective strategies

[00:14:49] to address this learning disabilities and recognized unique strengths and abilities of individuals with dyslexia. I will now entertain a motion to approve the consent agenda minus item 2.16, which has been moved to action item 10.1.

[00:15:09] Do I have a motion? Madam Chair. Yes, Vice Chair Donohue. I move that the school board approve the consent agenda minus item 2.16. I have a motion by Vice Chair Donohue. Do I have a second? Second. I have a second by Ms. Chernoff. It's been properly moved and seconded to approve the consent agenda.

[00:15:29] Is there any, oh, there's no discussion. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote? Yes. Clerk, would you please close and display the vote? That motion passes. 8-2 with Mrs. Griffiths abstaining for the vote. Okay, let's move on to our work session. Department of Academics,

[00:16:03] 2024-2025 Student Achievement Update presented by Dr. Ellis, Chief Academic Officer, and Dr. Tyler, Director of Research Assessment and School Improvement. And before we get into this presentation, I'd like to state that for me as a school board member and literacy advocate, this is one of the most important work sessions because we will be discussing assessment scores, achievement, progress monitoring, SOLs, and also what could be happening with accountability measures including SOL cut scores in the future. And this presentation is long because there's a lot of information that must be presented and discussed. It's a multifaceted and weighty topic

[00:16:43] and the length of the presentation and subsequent list of documentation reflects its importance. I will now yield the floor to you, Dr. Ellis. Thank you, Madam Chair. And Dr. Tyler and I will try to keep you entertained as we go through our 50 slides. So thank you for having us this evening. As Chair Mansfield mentioned, this is our annual student achievement data presentation. There is a lot of information in this presentation. There are also several attachments in BoardDocs for your review. We will not go through each attachment individually,

[00:17:20] but they are there for reference throughout. We also, if it's all right with you, Chair Mansfield, we'll pause after each specific data topic and turn it back to you to see if there are any questions or dialogue about that topic before moving to the next topic. So this evening we will share SOL achievement data, MAP growth, VALS, graduation, and SAT data. We'll also talk throughout the presentation about

strengths and opportunities for improvement as a division. And we'll start where we always like to start grounding ourselves in the strategic plan and keeping students at the

[00:17:58] center of all of our work. While we do have a lot to celebrate in this data we'll share this evening, we also have many opportunities for improvement, and I think it's important for us to address both with our ultimate goal that all students will achieve and reach their full potential.

[00:18:16] Most of the data in this presentation is now readily available to the public, both on the VDOE and LCPS websites. The links on this slide lead to two sets of school profiles. The first, The LCPS school profiles show enrollment data, accountability, assessment, attendance, and graduation.

[00:18:36] It can be disaggregated by school grade, student ethnicity, English learner status, students with disability status. The other link is to the VDOE school profiles. There you'll find information on demographics, student achievement, college and career readiness, program completion, school safety, and other aspects.

[00:19:00] of school functions, and all of this is sortable by school divisions and individual schools and subgroups within those categories. And if you would ever like to sit with Dr. Tyler or myself to go through those, we are more than happy to do that with you. So you will see strengths and celebrations in the data that we are sharing this evening. Overall, LCPS is a high-performing school division with above-average achievement, something that we should all be very proud of. We also have specific student groups to celebrate, such as increases in achievement across all subject areas

[00:19:37] this year for students with disabilities, and we are proud of the supports that we provide schools that have specific areas of need, whether it's through differentiated and flexible staffing or collaborative support from division offices. You'll also see that there are opportunities for improvement, especially in achievement levels and growth for students with disabilities and English learners. If we are truly to fulfill our mission and vision, we should celebrate our successes while also continuing to focus on closing these gaps and aiming for positive outcomes for each and every student. So with that, I'll turn it over to Dr. Tyler, and we'll start with SOL achievement.

[00:20:17] Thank you, Dr. Ellis. Good afternoon. So the next several slides will take you through many views of our state assessments, the SOLs. This one slide gives you kind of a snapshot of across four different content areas. And what you see here listed are overall students and then English learners or students with disabilities. These two groups we've selected over the years have represented our most sustained efforts to close achievement gaps. We do look at all other student groups. These two in particular have been a really sustained effort, as I said, across multiple departments to close gaps. So if we go to the next slide, looking at reading and math, you see that

[00:20:57] the last year before the pandemic in 18-19, what our performance looked like across the three groups. Now, while we're starting to approach those pre-pandemic level areas of performance or levels of performance, we're not seeing a substantive change in the closing of the achievement gaps.

[00:21:15] Each group is making progress, but as you see here, the slide allows you to see the extent to which we're seeing a close in the gaps. So that's reading and math. And you see for science, you see similar trends I would say in 2020 2021 that was one of the years we were coming out of the pandemic and we did have some differences in administration and participation rates so you may see some anomalies of certain

student groups but again significant growth for English learners in science but again while each group overall in English learners students with disabilities are seeing

[00:21:53] incremental improvements we're not seeing sustained closing of the gaps yet so looking at LCPS compared to the Commonwealth across all four all five areas we're seeing LCPS is outperforming the Commonwealth of Virginia as far as overall pass rates in the next slide you'll see similar data for looking at English learners higher than the state average in the area except for science but we also see not quite achieving the same levels of performance as the the overall student group.

[00:22:27] The next slide, you see students with disabilities, again, similar trends, outperforming the Commonwealth, but still differences with overall performance. And finally, economically disadvantaged, we actually see a lot of similarities with performance at the Commonwealth level.

[00:22:45] So the next slide, afterwards, you see a snapshot here. All students, students with disabilities, English learners, and as Dr. Ellis mentioned, some incremental gains for the student groups that we focused on historically, but still seeing significant outcome differences when we're looking at a snapshot, overall students with disabilities, English learners.

[00:23:10] Another way we look at SOL data is looking at students at that highest level of performance, that pass/advance range. To what extent are we getting students to that highest level of readiness? And we see compared to the Commonwealth, LCPS has seen a higher proportion of students reaching pass/advance, and it's just something we've looked at throughout the last several years, the extent to which we're getting students to that highest level.

[00:23:38] Now we look at comparisons with other divisions, similar divisions, similar demographics, similar size. We see that LCPS is pretty much matching or exceeding the comparable divisions here, the same score as Virginia Beach as far as overall reading performance.

[00:23:55] The next slide you see for math, higher than the comparable divisions at 82%. Science, Virginia Beach, a little higher there, but again, LCPS performing reaching or exceeding level performance relative to neighboring divisions, and finally, or similar divisions, and history, a more significant difference there.

[00:24:22] And as you will see in board docs, the same reports, you'll be able to see the pass rates by school in each of the four areas, which are available to you in the public. So looking at SOL performance, we're starting to, we're really progressing with having a state accountability system, a federal accountability system, and what we will call a local accountability system, meaning we're looking at the new SPSF indexes coming from the state.

[00:24:53] We also look at pass rates, and that allows us to take the best of an overall accountability system that gives schools points for students at different levels of readiness, but also a local accountability system that is geared to Dr. Spence's vision of getting outcomes for all students, the idea of 100% of students getting to proficiency.

[00:25:14] With that, we're able to identify schools for supports where a smaller subset of schools where we're engaging in needs assessments, we're analyzing data and ensuring that there's not only alignment in the school improvement plan, but also alignment in central office talent to support schools to ensure that those strategies are being implemented to close achievement gaps to raise overall student performance.

[00:25:36] and you see we have a targeted priority schools, a targeted support schools where we're integrating those systems. We're collaborating across division offices to accomplish that. Some of the schools will receive ongoing monthly planning and implementation that is more intensive where it may be shoulder to shoulder with coaches and additional supports to ensure that schools that may need extra support with ensuring that the CLTs are functioning at the highest level, that there's the highest implementation of the curriculum.

[00:26:09] There's flexible staffing available for schools, particularly those that may have more gaps they need to close. And again, continuing to utilize funds for high dosage tutoring. And so before I turn it back to you, Chair Mansfield, we did want to take a moment and just briefly address several changes that have come out from BDOE in the past several months that do impact school divisions and will impact their SOL scores, their pass rates in the future.

[00:26:43] So first of all, and all of these, I believe you have at least had a general awareness of, but I think it's interesting for us to talk about all of them in the context of student achievement. So House Bill 2686 regarding math acceleration, that went into place this summer.

[00:27:03] On June 30th of this summer, we were notified by VDOE that students who scored in the top 25%, the statewide upper quartile on their spring 2025 math assessment, their math standard of learning, were to skip a year of math and be enrolled in an advanced math course in the 25-26 school year. We already have a clear acceleration policy. We accelerate many of our students in mathematics, but we did comply. We communicated with families over the summer. As you can

[00:27:41] imagine schedules were already out, so it involved some clever scheduling, and we were able to work that out for all of the families that did opt-in. Families did have the option to opt out, and some did. So we did that. So that's one piece. The second piece is House Bill 1957, which you heard about in the spring, and that impacts standards of learning and potentially final grades. The bill indicates that a student's score on a standards of learning exam will actually count for a certain

[00:28:17] percentage of their final grade in the course. School divisions are currently waiting on specific guidance for how that will be implemented. So we currently don't have any more information than the actual language in the bill, but we are following that closely because that will have an impact, particularly on our grading and assessment policy. Additionally, hot off the presses from last Thursday, and we'll talk about that in a minute, is the revised SOL cut scores. So the State Board of Education voted to revise the cut scores, and I'll talk about that in a minute.

[00:28:53] And then finally, the thing that you're probably most familiar with because of the updates we've been providing you is the updated accreditation system that they're calling the school performance and Support Framework, or SPSF. So all of these things are in some ways connected, but in other ways also very siloed, and we're making sense of how they fit together and how they impact student achievement.

[00:29:20] So in a minute, I'm going to turn it over to Dr. Tyler to do a deeper dive in these revised SOL cut scores, but I did want to let you know, if you haven't seen it in news articles or other venues, that the Virginia Board of Education did vote last Thursday on revised cut scores that will go into effect starting with the spring 2026 assessment.

[00:29:44] So we've done some modeling based on last year's data that we have just shared with you around what that would look like for our students, and I'll ask Dr. Tyler to walk through that. And then

some updates that we don't have slides on, we're not really prepared to dive deeply into because it's happening as we speak.

[00:30:04] But I promise you that once Dr. Tyler's team has a chance to make sense of it, we get final data from the state later this week, tomorrow actually, right? We will prepare a presentation and bring it back to you for your information.

[00:30:23] So to summarize, as Dr. Ellison mentioned, there have been discussions over the last two-plus years around alignment of the SOLs with assessments like NAEP that get out a higher level of readiness or preparedness. So what was produced out of that and shared initially in August at the Virginia Board of Education meeting were proposed cut points, which were actually voted upon last week.

[00:30:48] So these represent alignment of the SOL proficiency levels more with the NAEP levels. And as you see here, it's listed, and as Dr. Ellis was saying, I guess it was in the news, a developing situation, which is it's actually evolved since last week where they've now introduced the state, idea of a different threshold approaching, which would be between the failed basic and proficient and an idea of a phased approach.

[00:31:14] We will be providing more updates on that. We have attended multiple meetings since last week, and as you see on the next slide, this is an actual estimate by our assessment office of if the cut scores before the approaching category were put in place, what our spring '25 results would have looked like.

[00:31:37] For example, our third grade reading pass rate would have actually been about 44% instead of 74%. And you see the differences there. The idea of if we aspire to a different level of readiness and a different cut point or a different level of rigor, we would have seen significant differences in the percentage of students who would have been deemed proficient.

[00:32:01] Now, I would say we will be providing an update where there's a transition plan where it'll be a more gradual adjustment to an approaching rate that will adjust it, and our scores actually would have looked a little bit more like our actual unchanged pass rates.

[00:32:19] So this is if the actual cut scores have been put in place with 2025 data for reading. And for math, you see similar differences there. So at this point, we finished the review of SOLs.

[00:32:37] if you had any particular questions as far as the content of this point. So thank you very much for this particular part of the presentation. I know I've been looking at SOS scores and things for about 10 years, and since the beginning, cut scores were measured about the number correct out of a set number of items for each grade.

[00:33:04] For instance, cut scores in 2006 for third grade were failed. basic was 13 out of 35, proficient was 23 out of 35, and advanced was 31 correct out of 35 items. Cut scores were lowered and approved in 2013 and then again in 2020. And at that time they even used a different way of doing standard setting called the modified ANGOF and they also used it for PALS. Now they've transitioned to a different standard setting process called item descriptor

[00:33:40] matching that at its foundation consists of a group of people reviewing each assessment item and asking the questions what does a student need to know and be able to do or to answer this item correctly and which performance level descriptor does this knowledge skill best match. They used this

new standard setting method to determine the appropriate recommended performance level cuts and also where on the scale a cut score falls and I'll be the first to say that I don't know that one standard setting method is better than any other but they both have pros and cons. What I do

[00:34:15] know is that this seems to be a rushed process. VDOE has implemented standard setting committees but has not followed up with any pilot studies or any modeling or even investigated what impact this will really have. We have no real understanding as to whether or not these changes are really going to do what VDOE believes that it needs to do and while in my opinion this may be well-meaning It's an experiment that is using our students as guinea pigs.

[00:34:43] And unfortunately, the students will be the ones who are harmed if this doesn't work out as BDOE thinks it will. Are these assessments truly measuring what they need to measure? Are the reading SOLs truly measuring reading proficiency? I understand wanting to better align with NAEP.

[00:35:01] However, I question whether this is the appropriate way to do it. In any case, the Virginia Board of Education has voted to significantly raise performance level cut scores on September 25th, and it must be remembered that it took us at least 15 years to decrease the scores to get where we are right now.

[00:35:26] And I really think that in order not to shock the system, perhaps there should be a step by step process, and I appreciate that Dr. Tyler was saying that they are looking at something like that but I really think that a measured approach combined with money for support and resources is super important. Passing the Virginia Literacy Act was a good first step but we still haven't even ensured there are graduating teachers who know evidence-based literacy instruction grounded in science-based reading research. Now to add to the growing concerns is the new law mandating that SOL test scores will contribute to 10 percent of a student's

[00:36:04] final grade in a course 7 through 12, in grades 7 through 12. What is that going to do to our students next year? I'd like the public to know that standards of learning assessments can be a good thing to help raise some overall red flags. However, right now, there is no way that I, as a literacy advocate for over 10 years, could trust any of this as providing any kind of useful information to make any kind of measure major decisions or even as a measure that just raises

[00:36:38] red flags i would much prefer a normed measure like map that is valid and reliable and measures both achievement and progress and i think we'll get back we'll do the conditional growth next but honestly i'm extremely disappointed in vdoe from doing this from many many years and being dyslexia advocate for many years and I'd encourage every single one of you to really look at these documents and what the board of education has voted on their process and ask questions because it's

[00:37:16] important to educate yourselves because this is going to affect all of our kids and our teachers and I'm sorry that was my I felt that it was important to say that speech because I've been doing it for so long and I'm really concerned so any other discussion Ms. Chernoff. Thank you madam chair um i too have definite concerns with this rollout from vdoe i'm a little encouraged to hear about the approaching approach i hope that that will help us um as i've been processing this since we've kind of started to hear about it and find out about it and i've been doing some more

[00:37:55] research myself with videoe i just i keep coming back to like some of the things that dr spence has said about we are remained commit we are remaining committed to making sure every student achieves and I think that's where our focus has to be as these ever-changing systems continue to move

around us because that's the thing that we can control and we can apply resources and funding and different things to help those students and so that's kind of where I feel safest right now in all this swirling around us so I do echo a lot of what you said I'm concerned too I'm very very concerned about it affecting our students grades they're already talking to us so much

[00:38:34] about the pressures that they face and, you know, having to be in a program and making sure they get to the right college and having these enormous GPAs and all of that. And I don't think that adding SOL scores to our grades helps any of that. And I'm grateful for the work in LAMP and our legislative agenda that was presented at our last meeting that we are going to, you know, advocate and we're going to tackle this at the legislative level. And so I'm very grateful for that.

[00:39:00] I do have a couple of questions about the cut scores, if that's okay. One of my questions is, you mentioned on slide 25, you have all four of those initiatives. So there seems to be a lot going on with cut scores and SOLs.

[00:39:17] These initiatives, are they sort of siloed or are they overlapping? That may be something that might be your opinion. I don't know that VUE is going to come out and specifically say that. But to me, it seems like they're very separate, because when you start to overlap them, I think there's some conflicts, which will lead to my next question.

[00:39:37] Yes. So that is a tricky question, and I don't know that there's a factual answer to it. We are trying to put them together. So we receive them as separate pieces of information, separate directives or bills, and I do think they should be connected.

[00:39:56] They're all around student achievement and assessment, and sometimes it's a little hard to put those pieces together. And if you don't mind, I'll just give you an example of that. So we had 770-ish students this summer, based on the House bill regarding math acceleration, who were accelerated in math.

[00:40:21] so we reached out to those families we actually reached out to more but 770 families wanted their child to accelerate based on this new house bill so we did if you overlay the new cut scores on top of that about 40 of those students would have actually failed their sol so that's an example of how they they really should be connected and aligned and and sometimes they're not you beat me to it that was my example too because we've just talked about this in cni and looking at those

[00:40:56] scores it just didn't add up so that i'm laughing it's not funny but it's concerning that that would be the case that we would accelerate kids that would now be deemed failing the sol so i'm kind of calling on voe to help us understand those overlaps um i also want to you know i can just looking at the data just as it is now without all of this coming into play i'm you know i'm going to sound like a broken record but I am deeply concerned that we are not closing gaps for our subgroups. I'm going to keep saying it till we're not saying it anymore and I just really really

[00:41:32] what does this do now to them? I mean if we're looking at a drop and you know of 30 percent difference in our overall SOL scores when our English language learners are at 36 percent passing that in my math that puts them at about six percent are going to pass and that I mean 36 is not acceptable to me at all but six percent is unfathomable so I'm concerned about that deeper impact and what those supports are going to be in in place um and then I think that's all I have

[00:42:10] for now the rest I have to do with Matt but um also I just shout out to the writing scores because we're crushing it and I'm so proud of us my literacy loving heart I just want to say like that is just awesome so I'll end on a high note any other any other discussion yes Mr. Straffy thanks chairman's field I'll keep my comments short as well I'm I do want to acknowledge the progress that we're making and to dr. Tyler's point right that incremental improvements don't mean that we're actually closing these gaps and I've been thinking about kind of the change the

[00:42:47] raising of the standards if you want to even call it that and to me I think the real question when I go back to the to our most vulnerable students or our highest needs schools I kind of want to change the conversation a little bit to me yeah I want to take this this situation and see how how we're gonna capitalize on this and maybe we change the question right or the conversation we say how are we you know go go from how are we currently supporting schools with achievement gaps or what resources are we adding or what you know we've had amazing conversations

[00:43:24] We've talked about how we've expanded English learner programs, our English learner program. We've talked about moving, you know, the progress that we've seen in taking English learners or special ed into gen ed. And we can talk all day about strategy and the things that we see are working and that we're moving the needle and seeing progress.

[00:43:46] But we do need to move the conversation to, what are we proposing to close the achievement gap, not to improve anymore? And I think that that is the challenge that's upon us as a school division of our size, of our reputation, of our abilities in terms of how we can fund our schools.

[00:44:10] And I know that that's a big question, and I know it's a huge burden, but I think we need to kind of take that and internalize it. And then part of that answer is then what goal does each school community have in terms of not just improving but closing the gap?

[00:44:25] So moving that question to the school community, and then obviously what resources do they need to close the gap versus improve, and really start to dial in to those types of strategies.

[00:44:42] And there's a lot of research and evidence out there around certain strategies, as you all know better than we do, But we need to bring those to the table and start to really make a dent. Any other? Yes, Ms. Chandler.

[00:44:59] Thank you, Madam Chair, and thank you so much for getting us kicked off on this very deep conversation, deep and meaningful and very purposeful work. I will say, as a 14-year LCPS parent, I have been in the system long enough that I can remember when we were talking about not having SOLs anymore.

[00:45:21] that was a long time ago. But I would like to ask what challenges exist in the system in terms of taking the SOL for students with disabilities? And when students have documented accommodation, is that accommodation available to them during the testing period in every way?

[00:45:44] So I will say, and I may ask Ms. Richardson to provide any specific details, but students do have accommodations for for their for their assessments i think challenges i mean and challenges still exist so your question is a little bit of a tricky one um but i don't know that it's i don't

[00:46:20] know it's the that it's the accommodations that are the barrier um if that if it makes sense right so we're not anticipating that it's a lack of accommodations that could be the barrier wouldn't think so I

don't I it's complex it's complex I think it depends and Miss Richardson would you add anything thank you dr. Ellis thank you mrs. Chandler for your question it's important to recognize that for students with disabilities that have individualized educational plans anytime their teams are coming together within the educational planning process and they're considering accommodations

[00:46:57] that are also applicable to standardized assessments. Those accommodations must also be applicable and put into place and implemented and practiced on a daily basis. So students with disabilities, their first time experiencing an accommodation is not during the SOLs.

[00:47:18] So I don't believe that the accommodations are a barrier to their participation. When you look across the body of our eligible students, which we have about 10,494 eligible right now, we're really looking at the impact of the brain-based challenges.

[00:47:40] And a lot of those brain-based deficits are in the language processing areas of the brain. And so really that combined with the structure of the SOL, the pacing and expectation, I think it's all of those factors put together that make the progress, while albeit beautiful, slower.

[00:48:07] I do want to say that a read-aloud, there's been a lot of challenges for a read-aloud for SOLs because there was an understanding that there should be a cut score as opposed to an IEP team decision.

[00:48:23] i know that that's been in the past and the thing that's interesting about that is it's only for the read aloud for the english the reading and they can still have a read aloud for science and history and so and sometimes you can even see that so in the reading here it's like a 53 but the history is higher and so i'm wondering if those students actually are using their read aloud because they can it's harder for them to get it for reading and I don't know have we have we sussed out the it's the IEP team decision and it's not a cut score on a on assessment that's a great question

[00:49:03] chair Mansfield we did have that back and forth and we did have to go back to the Virginia Department of Education to get them to weigh in because most school divisions across the Commonwealth were applying a cutoff score for the reading SOL for the read aloud, because essentially you still want to make sure that you're assessing reading comprehension.

[00:49:27] And so only eligible students under the IDEA that have documented decoding deficits are eligible for the read aloud of the English test. We have since removed the cut score, and we've clarified the language, and IEP teams are tasked with looking at diagnostic measures, looking at present levels of performance, going back and looking at eligibility information, and also making sure that our students with disabilities, for whom we are considering the read aloud for reading, have a documented decoding deficit and aligned annual goals.

[00:50:07] Ms. Chandler? No, I'm done. Anybody? Mr. Streffy. Just a last comment. We've talked in the past about, as you were mentioning accommodations, there's also a lot to be said about what schools are doing.

[00:50:31] One school in particular that I remember is the way they're engaging families and students around the SOLs and the distraction-free environment and just really setting the stage for success in the school, I think has seen some improvements.

[00:50:50] The other thing I just want to mention is that I made a grand statement about closing the achievement gaps, but at the end of the day, these are our most vulnerable students. We've been trying to close these gaps for a really long time across the country.

[00:51:06] The numbers that we're seeing in our most vulnerable students are the numbers that we see across the nation. And I think it's really important for LCPS to set its own goals, right? If we know what is our target based on what we're able to achieve currently and what we feel is based on the students that we serve, what should growth look like for them and what are the strategies to get there?

[00:51:36] Because we can say, well, every child needs to read at grade level by third grade. That is the goal. And what does growth look like year over year to get to that point? But I think that we really need, you know, coming from that English learner background, we need to just ground ourselves in the reality of the challenges that some of our students are facing in that they might have just arrived to the US and they might have different experiences.

[00:52:05] And it may not just be the language barrier that is affecting their ability to learn. And that's why we have some of the most amazing schools, specifically in our Title I communities that are able to serve these students and growth may look different for them, right?

[00:52:25] And I just, I said something before, but I wanna sometimes the way we talk about literacy and growth for our most vulnerable populations can be taken out of context. And I just wanted to kind of ground it in what some of the challenges that we're facing and the realities.

[00:52:47] And I think that LCPS just needs to figure out what closing the gap really means for us our schools thank you mr. Struffy any other yes dr. Spence thank you madam chair yeah I just quickly want to kind of just lean in mr. Struffy to your comment and thank you for that and thank you thank you all for the questions regards to this I think it's important to talk about growth in particular it's not something that we talked a lot about here and growth is part of our

[00:53:25] accountability model although it is important to point out that the current model called vivas is no longer going to be used and so one of the things we're still trying to figure out is what the growth model will look like as we look at accountability so i do think it's important for us to be paying attention to that as well because when we think about the achievement gap one of the key things that we need to be looking at is student growth right their growth every time so if a student comes to a teacher for whatever the reasons are and they are two grade levels behind

[00:54:01] in terms of proficiency and reading and that teacher is able to move them to grade levels forward and their other grade level proficient peers move forward appropriately a year that's that teacher's done a remarkable job with that student right and that growth measure can tell us that that's what's happening and so I think that's part of the equation that we also need to be thinking about and that I'm a little concerned that BDOE has not been clear about yet in terms of this new accountability model. And the other thing I just want to encourage us to think about when we talk about the achievement gap, when you think about it in the traditional sense,

[00:54:40] what you're doing is comparing children to other children. And unfortunately, you can't compare children to other children in any really meaningful way, right? And you've outlined some of the reasons for that. So you've heard Ms. Richardson talk about some of the brain-based challenges that our students with disabilities have, which create some language processing issues. And so when you're taking a test that is by nature built on the ability to kind of language process in real time, you're going to see some differences. When you're talking about students who have come into

[00:55:15] the country and our WIDA level one WIDA level two students who are still learning the language and are being asked to take a test that is in their non-native language you should expect to see differences in their performance versus students who are reading the test in their native language right and so one of the and this is by the way not not in any way shape or form to say we we can't do better we can do better we have schools that are doing better and one of the things I pointed out in our last principals meeting was if you have a school that's doing better and they're doing it because they're following specific strategies that we know work

[00:55:53] I kind of use the hospital analogy if that was a hospital and those were surgeons who had figured out how to improve patient outcomes then every other surgeon in the country would be at that hospital trying to figure out what they were doing and so we have an obligation to sort out the things that work and make sure that those are implemented in practice in each and every one of our schools and so you know for clarity that is the expectation that has been communicated to all of our schools and to our school improvement team as we have these guided discussions about our data at each school and it is also reasonable for us to to try to when we're talking about the achievement gap my personal

[00:56:33] perspective has always been the bar is a hundred percent success for all students and what we're doing is we're looking at groups of students against a hundred percent rather than trying to compare students to students right like we should want all kids to succeed and we should be looking at those groups those reporting groups against how well are they all doing against that vision of all of them succeeding and where's the growth towards that versus you know how are students with disabilities doing against black students doing versus white students do you know because that's just comparing different kids that that aren't really meaningful comparisons in my mind so know that that's our focus and i just want to reiterate and say to the

[00:57:12] board we are 100 committed to continuous improvement and growth amongst our students and seeing our students close the gap between their current levels of performance and 100 of our students reaching their goals thank you dr spence i will also add the computer adaptive testing for kids with disabilities who have learning differences they have holes and the computer adaptive models start with the foundation then they build they build they build they build well a kid with neurological differences might have might know a lot more high higher uh higher

[00:57:49] understanding higher comprehension but then lose some fundamentals and so then they have then they have a hole there and and they are stuck with a lower grade a lower uh a lower score as opposed to where they might be so it's testing is tricky like you said well and i do think it's worth noting that in in this moment where um you know the the the change to create more rigor in the reporting is to the cut scores there's no been no discussion about looking at the test

[00:58:24] themselves all right outside of sort of creating quote more standards more rigorous standards and I think that, to your point, there are a myriad of assessments that have been proven to be better for different groups of students, and the state is not engaged in that conversation whatsoever, and it's probably a really good time to do that.

[00:58:48] All right, Dr. Ellis, Dr. Tyler. All right, let's talk about growth. Speaking of growth, Dr. Tyler's going to talk about our MAPS course. Thank you, Dr. Ellis. So we are in our eighth year, maybe eighth year of MAP, maybe ninth year of administration of MAP.

[00:59:07] There's background information in the slide deck that are available for you. Again, it is adaptive. It measures growth over time. The next slide. We've utilized the conditional growth percentile. There are different metrics, and we've tried to utilize different metrics based upon their rigor, and there's also the importance of having a metric that's easily understandable. And that is one of the reasons why we set it on the conditional growth percentile, the idea of a student's growth relative to a peer group and the 50th conditional growth percentile being considered typical growth for that same peer group.

[00:59:42] And you see on the next slide an example of that and what happens if a student is at a particular achievement level and sustains typical growth, they remain at that achievement level. But if you have a student at a lower achievement level, one of the ways to close a gap to readiness is to accelerate and to accelerate more than what is typical as some of you have been talking about as far as setting goals that actually are beneficial to students, not necessarily always norm-referenced.

[01:00:10] So based upon that, we get to the next slide. You see here 50th condition growth percentile is what is considered typical or is typical relative to a peer group. We have shared data in the past shows that we're still in the 60th percentiles for achievement. So we're a high-achieving division that gets typical growth and sustains that high level of achievement. You see here, though, for certain groups, we're not sustaining that level of growth, as you see there, for English learners, students with disabilities. If a group is below the 50th condition growth percentile,

[01:00:46] they're losing ground relative to peers. So that's what you see for reading. And for math, a little different where there's a stronger overall math performance there as far as conditional growth, but then differences between the groups can sometimes lead to expansion of outcomes. So you see here over the last five administrations, we've gone from just the year after the pandemic being at the 44th conditional growth percentile from reading now to the 51st conditional growth percentile. We're starting to approach the growth that we saw before the

[01:01:21] pandemic. And you see there across some of the student groups, whenever we're not accelerating or above the 50th conditional percentile for a student group, we may be expanding gaps or outcomes. That's reading. Math, you see there's an even stronger kind of bounce back where we're pretty close to where before the pandemic, we're at the 53rd conditional percentile for reading, 54 for math. We're getting very close to that for math. And you see there are differences by levels. We provided this data because when we launched a map, we saw stronger growth at the

[01:01:57] middle school level, but that is pivoted. Recently, we've had ongoing conversations about explanations for that, and that is reading, and here is math. Again, a subset of students take math at the high school level, especially students who are not accelerated, so that's not representative of those students, but we're seeing stronger growth for the students who are taking math courses where they're not accelerating in high school.

[01:02:26] So these additional slides, you see differences here now. Dr. LaPaula, our MTSS supervisor, would say, when we're making decisions about identifying students for interventions, we utilize multiple assessments. So MAP, this is if MAP are utilized as the primary decider, but we do have decision trees here that may determine that.

[01:02:47] But this is giving you an idea of if MAP were the primary indicator, We're seeing acceleration for students in need of Tier 2, Tier 3 supports, which is what we want to see. Accelerating students who

may not be at a level of readiness that we're satisfied with, and we are seeing that acceleration in some cases meeting or exceeding our actual strategic plan goals for acceleration.

[01:03:10] So that's reading. And here it is for math. It's even more pronounced where we're seeing overall growth. And you see that students in need of Tier 3 supports if we were utilizing map only, but we do utilize multiple data points. It's very close to the 60th conditional growth percentile goal in our strategic plan.

[01:03:29] So we're seeing that we're accelerating students who are in greatest need of that acceleration based upon their readiness levels. And then you will see the actual MAP growth for last year fall to spring for each of the schools in reading and math.

[01:03:49] So before we move on, what questions might you have about the MAP data? Do we have any correlation or have we done anything about the the schools that were that we have high dosage tutoring in are we seeing any i know we've done some analysis i don't remember offhand the findings but we can definitely get that to you but we we've looked at analysis when it was funded by the state and we'll continue to look at analysis of performance of tutoring now that it's locally funded but we have done the difference

[01:04:25] between like the the company and the one-to-one tutoring we've done some analysis we can share cool uh any other questions uh miss shernoff thank you um i really appreciate this analysis and i was actually really curious about the elementary versus middle because i remember in the beginning it was reversed and i'm just wondering you know with what happened with covid and our youngest learners and those foundational skills now will we maybe see that kind of bounce back as it trickles up and i'm very curious about digging into that middle school data especially with reading as the new curriculum rolls out and as they experience

[01:05:00] a one-to-one assessment for the first time in reading and how they are addressing those interventions i think that that would be you know maybe something in pmc i would love to review and and dig into a little bit but um really encouraged by i think this is how we close those gaps we hit those numbers and encouraged to see some of those tier three kiddos in math hitting almost hitting that 60%. Would love to continue to see that as a goal for those tier three kids. Any other discussion? No. We can move on to VALS. So VALS is the Virginia Language and Literacy Screening

[01:05:39] System. It is now expanded K to eight. The data we're going to show you is from last year from K to five looking at the distribution of students by risk level from fall to spring. So as you see here, this is looking at it kind of as snapshots. And again, I think we have designations where not every student is taking it at every window. It's kind of based upon need. But we had 48% of students who identified as low risk in the fall who took the VALS assessment. And that increased to 59%

[01:06:14] by the spring. So we're actually seeing more students in that low risk category, which is where we want to see. Now the next slide, this may excite some board members who really like this particular chart, this is called a thank you chart. This actually, though, looks at the movement.

[01:06:32] So what you're seeing here is 44% of students were identified as low risk in the fall. It moved to 60% in the spring, but you see much of that movement or that gain came from the moderate risk students in the fall. And of course, you'll see in this that these are human beings, and sometimes when they take an assessment. It's a different experience, so we don't always see what we want to see, which is see students in

low risk, remain in low risk, so you see a little bit of movement there. But overall, you see the increase in the students' low risk coming

[01:07:08] from the moderate risk categories, but also continuing to focus on high risk. We actually did see that there was some movement there, but the percentage remained stable, but we saw movement out of moderate risk into low risk and we do also have an attachment in board docs with a more detailed breakdown of the vows assessment could you remind me uh when do you stop giving vows for every single student so you have a kindergarten you have kindergarten fall mid-year spring first uh first grade fall mid-year spring then second fall mid-year and then if they

[01:07:47] make an appropriate grade then is that when you stop giving it yes so required fall mid-year spring for kindergarten and first grade required fall and mid-year for second grade and spring for second grade for students at moderate or high risk and then third grade in the fall students new to virginia public schools and students who received summer intervention services and then

[01:08:21] optional for third grade mid-year. Because I just wanted to make sure that people knew that's why there was such a there could be you know you could see mid-year 1,603 students took it mid-year but then only 980. Exactly. That last year is because they didn't have to. Different group tested. Yeah I will just say that VALS is one of those is an you know an assessment that took three or four years to make with pilot studies and everything else and that's why we have it um i haven't you

[01:08:57] know i'm excited to see the fourth through eighth but um but it looks here that there was that our this is how we would see if our intervention is working right and it looks like we're doing a pretty good job so yay anybody else in discussion no okay all right graduation so the next two sets of data graduation and SATs we have local data we do not have the state and national data we will actually get that when the state does its press release

[01:09:33] and its release of data next week so as you see here for graduation this is the four-year graduation rate at LCPS we will fill this data in later when we get the state data overall graduation rate of 97% and we're seeing that there are some differences by student groups who are looking at English learners McKinney Vento eligible, and these are the trends over time, just the last couple of cohorts.

[01:10:06] And as SAT scores, you see that this is a snapshot and we will compare that to the state and global data when the state does its release. And the next slide will show you, this is the actual trend line that you'll see in more detail when you see the table on the following slide, which is over the years we've seen an increase in the SAT scores within Loudoun.

[01:10:31] from 1173 to 1187, and we'll fill in the comparison data to the Commonwealth and the country. Before I turn it back to you, Chair Mansfield, I will just reiterate that we are following closely along with the information coming out of BDOE.

[01:10:52] We expect more data to be released tomorrow, and as our team goes through that data, we will make sure to present that to you. are more than happy to come back to a work session or start in in PMC and I can talk with you about that and so with that I'll turn it back to you thank you so much is there a way that I would like to look at the vows per school per grade for all of these like at another time we can pull that for you thanks board

[01:11:29] members you have any discussion any questions any thoughts no I have about 15 minutes yes Ms. Chandler I just wanted to thank you again and thank you Dr. Spence for being so committed to really

digging in and I think there's a lot to be proud of here and I know that we have looked at specific districts I also anecdotally heard in the news that we have the highest scores in the

[01:12:05] Northern Virginia districts as well which isn't necessarily reflected here But I know that I would like to reiterate what my colleagues have said. I will not be comfortable with this until we can close some of those gaps. And I'm really committed to digging in and doing what we can to make sure that we're offering everyone the same opportunities.

[01:12:30] Yes, Vice Chair Donahue. Thank you, Madam Chair. Thank you, Dr. Ellis and Dr. Tyler, for the presentation. As you said, there is a lot to celebrate, although we have some work still ahead of us to do. I just wanted to comment on, I am very pleased to see our high graduation rates.

[01:12:54] I don't love the, on your slides, 48 and 49, the disparity with how much significantly lower Latino graduation rates are, and Indigenous Americans, the graduation rates for those groups are both appear to be quite a bit lower than other student groups and in particular those two groups had a decrease from 2024 to 2025 so i if you are digging into information more for pmc

[01:13:33] i would certainly be interested in in any potential reasoning that that you might have beyond behind why those groups in particular are at lower rates and ideas for how we can reverse those trends Thank you, Vice Chair Donahue.

[01:13:52] Okay. I think that's all. Looks like we still have about 15 minutes. Do we think that we could have a start with 1101, the fourth quarter's forecast? I think we could do that real quick before our case.

[01:14:12] So, Mr. Bergen, Dr. Bergen, sorry. Yes, Madam Chair, attached to this agenda item for the board members and the public is the fourth quarter forecast. These are the advisory updates for which we are planning to bring forward, as well as work session topics and information items that we're planning to bring forward during agenda planning for board meetings in October, November, and December.

[01:14:39] I'd be happy to address any questions from the board if you have any as to our proposed work plan as listed on the forecast. Yes, Ms. Chernoff. Thank you, Madam Chair. Thank you, Dr. Bergen. And just following up on a conversation that Dr. Spence and I had, if I was, we're seeing i'm hearing a lot about enrollment and so the numbers you know being down from i think almost 2016 is what we've heard so i was wondering dr spence if you'd be willing to speak to how we could have a presentation incorporated on enrollment in the next few months yes ma'am

[01:15:16] thank you for that we we look forward to the opportunity to discuss those enrollment trends it's something that cabinet has been paying quite a bit of attention to along with miss tate um and i believe and mr lewis you can nod your head or shake your head know uh that the intention is to bring that conversation into the conversation around the capital budget which you see there on october the 28th any other questions discussion okay i think everything else that we would take

[01:15:49] longer than five minutes so um with that um we'll go ahead and recess now for dinner and we will

[01:15:56] reconvene at 6 30.

[01:26:40] The board is now in recess. Good evening the board is coming out of recess at this time and we will continue with the pledge of allegiance and national anthem. I put my glasses on. Our pledge of allegiance and national anthem. Stonebridge has a long-standing choral tradition that has been

consistently supported and valued since the school opened in 2000. Encore is an auditioned ensemble singing SATB music. Okay, wait. Encore is an auditioned ensemble singing

[01:27:15] SATB music, which is soprano, alto, tenor, bass, and is the only vocal jazz ensemble in Loudoun County. This choir has been recognized with superior assessment ratings and has been selected to perform with the George Mason Jazz Singers. Bel Canto is a treble ensemble of 30 voices.

[01:27:34] Today, we have our senior choir members with us. Bel Canto is an auditioned SSAA ensemble that performs in a variety of genres and difficulty levels. This ensemble has also received superior assessment ratings. Last year, Stonebridge was recognized as a blue ribbon school, with all music disciplines receiving superior ratings.

[01:27:57] Stonebridge's director of choral activities is Christine G. Tarrant. She received a Bachelor's of Science in Music Education and a Master of Music Education, Choral Emphasis, from University of Illinois in Urbana-Champaign. Ms. Tarrant has been a choir director in the public and private sectors for 30 years.

[01:28:17] This academic school year, she will continue to teach treble choir, bass choir, bel canto, and encore, as well as dual enrollment music in society. We are thrilled to perform, they are thrilled to perform, the Star Spangled Banner for you, arranged by Dorman Meter.

[01:28:33] All right, everybody, if you would please rise for the National Anthem and the Pledge of Allegiance.

[01:30:44] Thank you very much. That was beautiful. All right, we're going to be moving on to item seven, our student school board representative comment. Tonight we have two school board representatives, and our first student is Julia Rad from Broad Run High School.

[01:31:02] Julia Rad was born in Lyman, Maine, and moved to Ashburn when she was three years old. She attended Ashburn Elementary Farmville Station Middle School and is currently a rising senior at Broad Run High School. Julia is actively involved in several organizations including DECA, National Honor Society, Teens for Christ, Interact Club, Student Council, and the Maroon Crew Student Section Committee.

[01:31:28] She also serves on Broad Run's Student Advisory Committee and the LCPS Super Attendance Advisory Council. Outside of school, Julia runs her own baking business, the Rad Bakery, works at a yoga studio, stays active through running and yoga, and remains engaged in church and a local community.

[01:31:47] She also enjoys spending quality time with friends and family. Welcome, Ms. Rad, and the floor is yours. Thank you, Chair. I would also like to thank the members of the Loudoun County School Board, Principal Spage, and the Broad Run community for allowing me to speak tonight.

[01:32:05] During the fall of my freshman year, I got injured and spent a lot of time sitting out of gym class. While this was very frustrating at the time, it gave me the chance to get to know one of my teachers, Coach John Costello. He was the kind of teacher that made every student feel welcome.

[01:32:24] He was kind, easy to talk to, and treated everyone with care and respect. He would tell me about a program he started many years earlier, urging me to participate in the upcoming event, Broad Run's Adaptive Field Day, which begun with just 20 senior volunteers and 10 special education students, has now grown into something remarkable.

[01:32:48] Twenty years later, the event brings together students from Broad Run, as well as our feeder schools, and has since expanded into other high schools in Loudoun County, such as Dominion, Heritage, Woodgrove, and as far as a high school in West Virginia.

[01:33:05] Held on the last day before Thanksgiving break, this event creates a space where students of all abilities can come together, have fun, and feel seen. Coach Koss tragically passed away in a car accident that December, but the spirit of his inclusion he believed in has never left our school.

[01:33:24] It lives not only through the field day, which has now been renamed the Coach Koss Field Day, but through many other programs as well. Broad Run offers several programs that connect students of all abilities throughout the year. One of them is our Unified Theater Program.

[01:33:43] Students in the special education program are paired with their peers to create and perform a full production together. This gives the space for students of all areas to build friendships and a community doing what they love. Our unified basketball team does something similar, and in this club, students of all abilities train, practice, and compete in games side by side.

[01:34:07] Their first game is scheduled for the beginning of this December as well. Lastly, Broad Run houses a student-run cafe, a Cup of Spartan, which is operated by students in our special education programs. They take orders, prepare drinks, and serve the staff and students of Broad Run throughout the week.

[01:34:28] It's a space where they gain real-world experiences, connect with the school community, and take pride in their work. And if you've ever been in line for coffee, you know just how popular it is. Through all these programs, I have seen how Broad Run makes sure that all students, including those in the special education community, are included in every part of school life.

[01:34:52] From pep rallies, to within the classroom, to extracurriculars, inclusion is not something extra at Broad Run, and it's something normal. And as a senior, I truly believe that this has made our whole student body more compassionate, connected, and aware of the world beyond ourselves.

[01:35:11] Thank you. Thank you, Ms. Rad, for being here and for your comments. Our next student is Nadia Estevedia, and she's a senior at Parkview High School and is currently serves as a student body president.

[01:35:33] She's a dedicated student involved in multiple honor societies and clubs, demonstrating a strong commitment to academic excellence, leadership, and service. Nadia is passionate about student success and fostering a strong sense of community within her school.

[01:35:49] She represents the voice of her peers with integrity and enthusiasm. Welcome, Ms. Echeverria, and the floor is yours. Thank you, Chair Madam. Buenas tardes. My name is Nadia Echeverria. I am a senior and currently serve as the student body president at Parkview High School.

[01:36:10] Tonight, I would like to start by stating the obvious. For too long, our school has been underestimated. Every year, we've heard negative comments, comments about race, poverty, and drug abuse. But the reality is that you cannot define Parkview unless you have witnessed.

[01:36:25] what I call the Parkview experience, and I would like to highlight how Parkview deserves to be celebrated. This evening, I sit here in front of you to share the story of the new chapter that is unfolding at our school. As many of you know, Parkview is getting a brand new building, opening its doors for the 2020-

2027 school year. So far, the foundation of the structure is slowly being built, but deeply rooted in that Parkview experience that I will be talking about. What's even more exciting is what will be happening inside the building, full of diversity and back with a loving community. Parkview will begin offering the International

[01:37:03] Baccalaureate program, one of the most rigorous and respected academic programs worldwide. Parkview will not only be recognized as the most spirited during PEV rallies, but as the newest IB program school. IB classes will challenge students to think critically, connect learning across subjects, and apply knowledge to real-world issues. We have built and are continuing to create a community where every student has the opportunity to thrive. This past January we had our first mid-year graduation, where we had eight seniors graduate.

[01:37:37] A few months later, we got to see 359 students walk the stage. Marking the biggest graduating class, on October 18th, we will gather for our 2025 Night in Hawaii Homecoming. But homecoming at Parkview is more than a dance.

[01:37:53] It's a celebration to kick off the new school year. During homecoming season, we received many donations from the Sterling Park community, which reminds us of how strong our community is as a whole and highlights how homecoming is just another aspect of the great Parkview experience.

[01:38:10] Parkview might not be the perfect school in an outsider's eyes, but to me, it's the most admirable school in all LCPS. Walking to the front foyers and admiring all the flags attached to the ceiling, recognizing our student diversity makes me incredibly proud. From the first time I stepped into the school, I felt heard, recognized, and cared for.

[01:38:31] My Parkview experience has been beyond perfect, And I hope students get to appreciate their own heartbeat experience, full of love, service, and care, just like I and many others have. And tonight, I invite you all to join in celebrating our successes and not just pointing out our perceived shortcomings.

[01:38:51] We have one of the most talented marching bands in the county, winning first place overall and winning best music and best general effects in the SoCo Invitational just last week. Our band will also be performing at the Wizards game this October. We also have one of the best wrestling, soccer, and track teams in the states, and have graduates now competing at the collegiate levels.

[01:39:13] Tonight, I want to leave you with this thought. Parkview is not the school people once labeled as us. We are innovators, leaders, athletes, artists, and scholars. We are a community of students that come from different backgrounds, but have the same dreams and passions as every other student in Loudoun County.

[01:39:32] With a great new building, new opportunities like the IB program, and a student body full of determination, Parkview is, and will always be, stronger than ever. I would like to thank the members of the school board, Dr. Spence, Dr. Jefferson, my advisors, Mr. Bailey and Ms. Primus, and of course, my Parkview community, for allowing me this opportunity to speak and represent us here tonight.

[01:40:04] Thank you again for your continued support. Thank you, Ms. Estrevera, for being here and for your comments.

[01:40:22] We'll now move on to item 8, which is the superintendent's report presented by Dr. Aaron Spence, our superintendent. Dr. Spence. Thank you, Madam Chair and members of the board. It is, as

always, my pleasure to share some good news from around our school division.

[01:40:40] First, Light Ridge High School Technology Student Association students showed their STEM skills on the national stage this summer, competing and winning at the TSA National Conference in Nashville. similar to the middle school conference which was highlighted at the previous school board meeting the high school conference offers more than 40 competitions challenging students to design problem solve and innovate across a range of stem topics our lightridge students participated in events such as architectural design drone challenge and dragster design and two of the lightridge students chase thoden and caleb dunn earned first place in the technology problem solving

[01:41:16] event a competition challenging students to apply critical thinking collaboration and creativity to real world scenarios the success of these students highlights lcps programs like tsa build critical thinking and problem solving skills preparing our students for life after high school next we'd like to congratulate the 69 lcps students who have been named national merit semi-finalists these lcps students were amongst the 1.3 million high school juniors who entered the 2026 national merit scholarship program by taking the 2024 psat which is an initial screen

[01:41:51] for program entrance. National Merit Semi-Finalists are eligible to compete for one of three National Merit Scholarships and recipients of those scholarships will be announced next spring and summer. We'd like to congratulate Catherine Reiser, LCPS Data Science Supervisor, for being named one of Loudon's 40 Under 40 honorees. The annual Loudon 40 Under 40 awards recognize rising business and community leaders by honoring 40 bright stars under the age of 40. Winners are profiled in the Loudon times mirror and honored at an awards banquet shine which stands for spotlighting heroes in

[01:42:28] education is back for the 2025-26 school year this joint loudon education foundation and lcps initiative recognizes staff members who go above and beyond in support of our students and the community this month's shine award winner is marty reinhardt construction supervisor who was nominated by hamilton elementary principal kelly mesensall for his exceptional dedication and support during the vestibule project at Hamilton Elementary last year.

[01:42:57] Members of the LCPS community, including other staff members, students, and parents are invited to nominate LCPS staff who SHINE. These award recipients receive a gift worth \$500, coordinated by the Loudon Education Foundation, and more about SHINE can be found at the website shown on this slide.

[01:43:16] I am very proud to share about the launch of the Family and Community Engagement, or FACE Teacher Cohort, a new professional learning initiative. This cohort equips educators with knowledge and resources to build strong family partnerships, create welcoming school environments, and foster responsive engagement that supports student success.

[01:43:35] Over the next eight months, participating teachers will engage in monthly hybrid sessions, collaborating on best practices, and completing a capstone project. In doing this, they will strengthen LCPS's commitment to our family-school partnerships and inclusive and connected communities.

[01:43:50] This opportunity is unique because it's designed specifically for teachers, and it's inaugural year this small but mighty cohort is breaking ground and expected to grow each year becoming a model for other divisions to emulate. This cohort and the divisions work with family and community engagement exemplify our ongoing dedication to ensuring every student thrives through these meaningful

partnerships. The Loudon Education Foundation a key LCPS partner and supporter of LCPS students and staff recently shared its 2025 annual report. This report's a reflection of a year filled with impact innovation and community collaboration with the support of

[01:44:29] local partners and donors LEF to help expand opportunities for LCPS students and educators here's a quick look at what Leland Education Foundation accomplished LEF invested nearly five hundred thousand dollars in student health and well-being activities such as supporting LCPS's mobile health clinic and the LCPS recovery academy LEF served nearly 50,000 meals through the field program, which supports in-school food pantries and weekend meal bags for students in need. And LEF awarded \$90,000 in innovation and education grants, which support our LCPS teachers

[01:45:05] and students by helping to fund innovative classroom and teaching activities. These numbers tell a story of progress and the power of working together. So many thanks to LEF for their support and for being a partner in our student success. And then finally, this evening, I would like to take a moment to highlight the recently released LCPS innovation and achievement report we are proud to share the story of how our schools together with our families community partners and dedicated staff continue to provide every student with the opportunities resources and encouragement needed to thrive together with our amazing staff supportive community and committed

[01:45:41] families LCPS is ensuring that every student has a pathway to success that reflects their strengths honors their aspirations and prepares them for the world ahead and i encourage our community to read this report which can be found at the website seen on this slide madam chair that concludes my report thank you dr spence um that will now bring us to item nine which is public comment thank you for engaging with the school board through the public comment process the school board welcomes comments from louden county residents and believes that a strong community engagement and outreach are are important components of a successful school system.

[01:46:21] Speakers must limit comments to the time allotted. Based on the number of speakers and the agenda this evening, all speakers have been allotted one minute each for public comment. Please be advised that speakers who miss their time slot will not be called at a later time.

[01:46:38] All audience members shall maintain civility, decorum, and respect for the functioning and dignity of the school board at all times. Please remain seated unless arriving, departing, speaking at the podium, or during a break. Violations of civility, decorum, and respect include shouting, heckling, jeering, applause, or other noise which disrupts or delays the meeting.

[01:47:00] Obstructing speakers from being able to see the school board and vice versa. Interrupting speakers. Attempting to speak when not called to do so by the chair. And approaching a speaker or otherwise attempting to intimidate, disparage, or distract a speaker, staff member, or other meeting attendees.

[01:47:19] Speakers should refrain from vulgarity, obscenities, defamation, profanity, or other like breaches of respect, nor may speakers target, criticize, or attack individual students and or individual division employees during public comment.

[01:47:35] As a reminder, School Board Policy 2520 states speakers may not target, criticize, or attack individual students during public comment. speakers should communicate those concerns to their school principal or an appropriate school official. The school board requests that comments on an individual

student or employee-related matter not be shared at public meetings where the disclosure could violate applicable confidentiality requirements. I do want to take a moment to clarify a few things. As I have explained previously,

[01:48:09] speakers can personally identify a student or employee without stating a student's or employee's names. That is, personally identifiable information is any information that a reasonable person can link together to pinpoint an individual student or employee, and where that individual student or employee is known to others in their school and surrounding community based on the context that is shared. The school board welcomes you to share your concerns, but asks that, to the extent you have prepared remarks that target, criticize, or attack any individual students or employees,

[01:48:46] you generalize such remarks to ensure compliance with board policy. For example, comments that targets or criticize or attack a student or an employee or a student or an employee from a specific named school or a student or an employee with characteristics where the information would personally identify that student or employees to others in the school or broader LCPS community would violate school board policy however comments that discuss general concerns with students

[01:49:24] or employees at schools and do not target criticize or attack an individual identifiable in student or employee are permissible under school board policy i as the school board chair am charged with the responsibility to maintain order during school board meetings accordingly when reasonable, I will warn of breaches of decorum, civility, and respect, and ask speakers to redirect their comments prior to possibly discontinuing individual speaking privileges or taking other actions to preserve the civility, decorum, and orally conduct of the meeting.

[01:50:03] Such action includes calling a recess in order to maintain and or restore order. If speakers fail to comply with school board policy regarding public participation, you will receive a warning and request to redirect or generalize your comments.

[01:50:20] Should you fail to redirect or generalize your comments after that warning, you may be asked to yield the microphone, at which time you should yield the microphone, as well as the floor, and take your seat, and I will then call the next speaker. To the extent necessary, I will also warn of breaches of decorum, civility, and respect from attendees prior to taking other actions to preserve the orally conduct of the meeting.

[01:50:47] Speakers should face the dais and direct their comments to the school board. Per school board policy 2520, members of the school board will not answer questions or respond directly to the public during public comment period. Violations of decorum or civility by any meeting attendee may result in the chair directing staff to remove the attendee for the remainder of the meeting.

[01:51:11] Repeated or persistent violations of decorum or civility by the audience may result in on the decision of the chair. Public comment being tabled until a later point in the meeting's agenda. Limiting the number of attendees in the meeting room during public comment for safety reasons.

[01:51:26] Or, the public comment period ending for the evening. Copies of materials for board members should be given to the public information officer in the media box at the back of the boardroom before the start of the meeting. Please provide 12 copies of the materials.

[01:51:43] Under no circumstances may a speaker approach the dais. The public is reminded that access to school board meetings is available through LCPS-TV on Comcast Channel 18 and 1070 HD and Verizon

Fios Channel 43. The live stream of the meeting may be viewed on the website.

[01:52:02] We look forward to hearing your comments. And just because I think there's a lot of new people out there, there's no clapping. This is your clapping. Just letting you know ahead of time. So we will now start with our virtual public comment.

[01:52:19] Our first one is Jessica Flores, followed by Michael Callahan. Good evening, members of the board. I'm here today not just as a Loudoun County resident, but as a parent deeply invested in a successful model, Hisboro Charter Academy.

[01:52:40] I urge you to support HTA's necessary inclusion in the capital improvement plan, safeguarding this public asset. HTA represents the very best of public education. My daughter has just started kindergarten this year, and every morning her eagerness to go to school and her genuine curiosity and happiness validates our choice. Parents consistently note the engaged staff means that a child will want to go to school every morning. The results are undeniable. The Virginia Board of Education recognizes HCS with the prestigious Highest Achievement Award as an exemplar of school for the 23-24 school year. This is not merely an honor, it's evidence-based. Our students achieve a 92% proficiency in reading and a level of literacy

[01:53:19] and excellence that contributes significantly to the entire division's reputation. We ask that you please support us in being part of the capital improvement plan as it is a part of our community, and it will only benefit Loudoun County as a whole. Thank you. Michael Callahan, followed by Scott Brainerd.

[01:53:39] Callahan, I'm a technology business owner, and I serve on several advisory boards at Virginia Tech. I speak in support of HCA and the objectively positive educational outcomes it achieves for students. Excluding the high-achieving charter schools through capital funding would unfairly single them out.

[01:53:59] It would jeopardize the facilities and it would risk driving them out of existence, which in turn jeopardizes the board's own achievement goals we spoke at length about this afternoon. Around the world, and even next door in Montgomery County, which just invested \$10 million in early education, leaders are expanding programs at work, not effectively defunding them.

[01:54:19] The charter schools are public schools. Their students are Loudoun students. They deserve the same safe, well-maintained learning environments as their peers, supported by the same tax dollars. I urge you to reject a blanket capital funding exclusion and instead adopt a balanced path that protects students, positive outcomes, and fiscal responsibility.

[01:54:39] Thank you. Thank you. Scott Brainerd, followed by Heidi Vermette. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Heidi Vermette, followed by Brenda Bengson.

[01:55:01] Pressing support from Hillsborough Charter Academy and its independence. But independence means nothing if we cannot exist, and we cannot exist without funding to secure a future. Without capital funding to keep a safe roof over our head in future years, HCA cannot connect our scholars to teachers and scholars in Nigeria.

[01:55:21] Without capital funding to maintain LCPS-owned buildings, HCA cannot connect our scholars to astronauts on the ISS, as we have done. And without that funding, scholars like my daughter cannot connect to the Loudoun County Public School System.

[01:55:38] She is currently thriving at Harmony because in fourth grade, she was offered the opportunity to attend HCA, when we have thought homeschooling was our only option. You cannot support HCA and its independence without supporting HCA by allowing it to receive capital funding.

[01:55:55] Thank you very much. Thank you. Brenda Bankson, followed by Andrea Weiskopf. Candidates pretend to care, yet dehumanize students. Politicians say, follow the rules, yet ignore legal precedent. School board members state that 1% of our students don't matter. LGBTQ and minority students are targeted with hate. We resist and ask, where's the love?

[01:56:30] The Black Eyed Peas sang, but if you only got love for your own race, then you're going to leave space for others to discriminate. And to discriminate only generates hate. And when you hate, then you're bound to get irate. Madness is what you demonstrate. And that's exactly how hate works and operates. Man, we got to set it straight. So where's the love? Stay strong for our students.

[01:57:01] one percent or 99 thank you andrea weiskopf followed by bradford greg we do not have a virtual public speaker by that name bradford greg my name is brad greg and i'm a member of the hillsborough community hillsborough charter academy uh parent team representing the the group here tonight i urge you to amend policy 5410 so that hillsborough and middleburg charter academies

[01:57:37] remain eligible for capital funding just like every other public school in the county These schools are proven successes. With small class sizes, passionate teachers, and strong family partnerships, they consistently deliver some of the highest test scores in Loudoun. The long wait list shows just how deeply the community values and trusts them.

[01:57:54] More than that, they serve as innovation hubs, piloting approaches that benefit the entire LCPS system. But like all public schools, HCA and MCA need access to capital funding for safe, well-maintained facilities. Denying that support would shift costs to parents and break the commitment made when these schools were founded.

[01:58:12] Just last year, this board recognized the importance of supporting HCA, and I ask you to honor that commitment now. Every public school student deserves equitable resources and a safe environment to thrive. Please continue. Thank you. My understanding is through a Let's Talk that someone said the link wasn't working.

[01:58:39] I'm guessing you're referring to the live stream? No, for public comment. We had five of our seven able to join and validate that the link was working.

[01:59:02] Okay. We'll move on to in-person speakers, starting with Ashley Hambrick, followed by Carrie Very. Good evening. Thank you so much for your commitment to our students, and thank you for hearing me out tonight.

[01:59:27] My name is Ashley Hambrick, and I am the mother of a Hillsborough Charter Academy scholar. I'm also a business owner serving children and students with autism in Loudoun County, and I'm here to tell you about how amazing these charter schools are.

[01:59:43] Before starting the charter school, my son asked me to homeschool him. He struggled socially to connect, and he found it difficult to be engaged and challenged academically. Now, when I get him from the bus stop, the first thing he says to me every day is, can I go back to my school?

[02:00:02] And it's just been a godsend. And Hillsborough's hands-on, project-based learning approach and close-knit community is exactly what my son needs, and many other kids, too. And I know that you share my concern that each student is treated equitably.

[02:00:19] The proposed policy 5410 to make Hillsborough Charter Academy ineligible for capital funding threatens the equal treatment of my child. Thank you. Carrie Berry, followed by Nick Smith. Good evening.

[02:00:36] My name is Carrie Berry, and I have two children that attend Middleburg Community Charter School. I have a first grader and a fifth grader. and my fifth grader started at Middleburg Community Charter School when she was in second grade and this was the aftermath of COVID and she was really struggling to read. She was not reading at the second grade level and although she was not an overnight success it did take years for her to catch up but by the end of her fourth grade year she was thriving academically doing very well in the classroom and she passed all three of her SOLs math, Virginia studies, and reading and

[02:01:14] not only did she have success the entire fourth grade had success for virginia studies the entire fourth grade passed 100 sols so i am here because i would like you to keep capital funding for these schools that need to be safe for these kids to learn thank you thank you nick smith followed by

[02:01:38] brian king no nick smith hey brian king followed by uh casey zobel good evening lcps school board Loudoun County has 62 public elementary schools.

[02:02:08] Two of these are a little bit different. They're public charters. They're open to every student in the county, fully free, and within the LCPS ecosystem. My three boys have thrived in HCA. Isn't that right, Brayden? As a board member at Hillsborough Charter, I've been more involved with their education in the community than I ever could have imagined, and I'm thankful for that.

[02:02:26] But tonight, I urge you to vote no against policy 5410. This policy says the 288 students attending HCA in Middleburg are financially worth less to LCPS than their peers. Policy 5410 says that teachers and staff at the charters are worth less to LCPS and their counterparts at the other 60 public elementary schools in the county.

[02:02:47] Policy 5410 is misguided. It's not equitable, and it's not inclusive. It doesn't support the diversity that we bring to the county as a small, innovative public charter. Please include HCA and Middleburg in SIP and CAP funds and vote no against Policy 5410 because our students in charters are not worth less. They are worth it.

[02:03:06] thank you Casey Zobel followed by Bonnie Branding thank you guys for being here today we appreciate you guys listening to us my name is Casey Zobel I have a first grader at HCA and we absolutely love that school also I'm a nurse anesthetist and I love what I do so bear with me because a lot of my people are sedated when I see them so obviously not a public speaker so I meet a lot of different people. And you know what? There are different races, different genders, different everything.

[02:03:45] I don't care where they live. But I feel like we might be taking that into consideration for this topic of 5410. So I'm asking that you don't treat me or treat our school separate. I want you guys to treat us as equals. So right now our children are being put at a disadvantage solely because we live in Percival and we go to a school that is closest to us. Please help us be treated as equals and have funding for HCA so we can continue thriving and do great grades as well as a great, awesome community.

[02:04:16] Thank you. Thank you. Bonnie Branding, followed by Kristen Kinney-Haynes. Hello. I'm so encouraged by what I've heard over the past hours here.

[02:04:32] A lot of the things that I've heard on other topics today mimic what I wanted to talk about on Hillsborough Charter Academy. I heard a lot about inclusion. I heard about those seeking the surgeon who figured it out. We figured it out at HCA. This is my eighth year at Hillsborough Charter Academy as a parent and an active volunteer.

[02:04:51] I'm clearly a Loudoun County resident and taxpayer. I own two Loudoun County small businesses in the area. I served as co-chair of a small business leadership team in Loudoun County, team manager of various activities here in Leesburg for my children as well. I see and interact with our greater community on a daily basis, and I've never seen the greatness that I see at HCA, and that comes from deep in my heart.

[02:05:13] It's a wonderful school, and it will cease to exist if we're not able to support it the way that we support our other schools. Put a roof over our head, and we'll keep producing the top test scores that you find very valuable in the county and that the state finds very valuable.

[02:05:29] Thank you so much for your time. Thank you. Kristen Kinney-Haynes, followed by Mark Wurdeheimer. Hi, I'm Kristen Kinney-Haynes. Like most fifth graders this year, My daughter began school in anything but a traditional school setting, but the capable teachers of LCPS ensured she thrived during COVID kindergarten.

[02:05:53] Grade 1 was nowhere near traditional either. Masks, extra recess, and as an above-level reader, a lot of free time with her peers. Grade 2, also non-traditional. Her teacher's retirement was approved the week school started, and she spent the school year with a string of subs, long and short term.

[02:06:10] Third grade was her first year of traditional schooling in LCPS. She showed up every day, she sat at her desk, she did her work, she continued to perform, and she developed an anxiety-induced ulcer brought on by the need to sit quietly and conform to the confines of a truly traditional LCPS classroom.

[02:06:26] Loudon strives to educate all students and the availability of HCA and MCCS make it possible that even our youngest learners can find their best fit, not just the high school kids. When I say our daughter's life was changed for the better and a change that will have lifelong positive impacts because of Middleburg Community Charter School, I do not exaggerate.

[02:06:44] Thank you. Thank you. Mark Wertheimer, followed by Francisco Lara. Hello, I'm the previous principal of HCA, so I'm going to tell you, I've heard enrollments down in Loudoun County Public Schools, and I've also heard that home, private, and cottage schools are exploding.

[02:07:07] For years, the LCPS has the dubious political distinction of being in both Virginia and national news, and not always in a good way. Let's use some of the many success stories coming out of little public schools like Waterford, Lincoln, Aldi, Hamilton, and the charter schools as a means to promote a positive publicity campaign. For a very small percentage of available capital improvement dollars, LCPS can continue to garner accolades as the most advanced charter school district in the state of Virginia. No need to forbid the charter schools for participating capital expenditures. The board should continue to allow these small schools to access funds as approved by this board on a case-by-case basis, rather than exacerbate the public black eye LCPS has

[02:07:46] been wearing too long by forbidding bipartisan charters from participating in these funds. Why worsen that black eye by reversing a decision made just one year ago to allow participation in these funds. What a great public boon that would be for this district. Thank you, Francisca Laura, followed by Tegan Tucker.

[02:08:05] Hi, my name's Francisca, and I'm in second grade at HCA.

[02:08:24] I love my friends. I love my teachers. Please don't take my school away from me. Thank you. Tegan Tucker, followed by Avery Bice. I'm an eighth grader and a proud former HTA student.

[02:08:48] I'm here because a new policy is making it really hard for HTA to get their funding for major building repairs. If HTA can't get this funding, they might have to take money meant for educational programs like our amazing E3 hands-on projects to fix things like the air conditioning. That's unfair.

[02:09:04] HTA really prepared me for middle school, especially related to teamwork and science stuff. But the students there deserve a better facility. For example, our school musical was hard because the music room was on the stage and we had to go all the way to the Old Snow School to plan on a show. Now that I'm at Harmony, I see what a difference it makes to have a separate music room and a real place to perform.

[02:09:21] HDA students deserve that too. We're all Loudoun County Public School students. Other students get help with their major upkeep projects from the county, and HDA is a public school just like them. Please don't go back on your word. Please let Hillsborough Charter Academy have access to the funding it needs, and please let more scholars explore, engage, and engineer.

[02:09:38] Thank you. Thank you. Avery Bice, followed by Meredith Ray. Hello, my name is Avery Bice and I'm 11 years old. I am a proud alumni of Hillsborough Charter Academy. I am here today to ask that the school board amend the proposed policy 5410 to allow HCA to have access to capital funds. Our scholars, families, teachers, and staff all deserve to be

[02:10:14] treated the same as every other school in Loudoun County that is paid by tax dollars. I ask that you please amend this policy so HCA can have access to this funding. They need more space for PE and STEAM so kids can move and learn. They need better spaces for art and music classes, and they need important things like security fencing around the playground so kids can feel safe and enjoying being outside. I've moved on to middle school now, but my brother and sister

[02:10:49] are still at HCA. They deserve the same kind of space for activities I have at Harmony Middle School. Thank you. Thank you. Meredith Ray, followed by Kimberly Knoble. No, Meredith Ray.

[02:11:17] Kimberly Knoble, followed by Deborah Collins. Good evening. On September 16th, 2020, we heard four words we never thought possible. Congratulations. It's a girl. After years of heartbreak from multiple miscarriages, we finally gave birth to our sweet Evelyn Grace, the center of our whole world. We were nervous, anxious to send her off to kindergarten. However, HCA has been a beacon

[02:11:55] of hope and joy for our family. Evelyn is thriving academically, socially, and emotionally. The thought of losing this incredible school is devastating. It is more than just a building. It is a community that fosters growth, inclusion, and excellence.

[02:12:16] No longer funding HCA would not only disrupt Evelyn's development, but the lives of other families who rely on it as a cornerstone of their child's education. My husband and I respectfully ask the

board to reconsider the language in Policy 5410.

[02:12:33] He and I are... Thank you. Thank you. Deborah Collins, followed by Eric Callender. Hi, my name is Debra Collins, and this is my fifth year as a parent volunteer at Middleburg Community Charter School. On any given day after school, you can see a large group of children begging their parents for them not to leave school.

[02:12:58] We don't have a problem with school refusal at Middleburg Charter School because the kids love it so much. In addition to learning science, reading, math, they get a chance to really dive deep into the arts, dance, music. And our scholars are thriving in those programs, as well as passing all of their grades as well, their scores.

[02:13:22] SOLs and MAP scores as well. I'm asking you today that you consider giving us, all we're asking for is the bare minimum for our children. We're not asking for anything elaborate. We just want the basic needs to be met, like a roof over our scholars' heads, maybe possibly windows, air conditioning, bathroom, and we'll cover the rest.

[02:13:44] Thank you. Thank you. Eric Callender, followed by Paul Vickers. Good evening. I'm Eric Callender from Middleburg. Madam Chair, I thank you for your statements earlier about dyslexia. My sister has it and has two children in our schools as well.

[02:14:02] My kindergartner attends Middleburg Charter Community School. and her little sister's right behind her. It's a Loudon public school in a school board-owned building. She feels known and safe, and that sense of safety depends on the basics. Life safety systems, structural upkeep, and ADA code compliance.

[02:14:21] Policy 5410 is proposed to remove her school from the programs that fund those basics. I'm not asking for extras, just the same essential building support other Loudon schools receive. Please keep her school covered for all these essentials through the division's maintenance and capital programs, or at least grandfather, existing schools if the policy needs to change.

[02:14:40] So Hurlouton School is held to the same safety standards as every other school. I emailed you guys at the beginning of this meeting a proposed amendment for this, if you would consider it. Thank you. Thank you. Paul Vickers, followed by Shelly Norris.

[02:15:01] Hi, I'm Paul Vickers. I'm the principal of Hillsborough Charter Academy, and I love Loudoun County Public Schools. Between my wife and I, I think we've given over 70 years to the children of Loudoun.

[02:15:18] And one of the things that I think all of you hang your hat on is providing choice and providing differentiated learning opportunities for our children. Just at the high school level, I marked down a few of those special opportunities.

[02:15:34] HamSci, IB, Roby, the academies, one of my sons went to the academies, TJ, ROTC, Northstar, Access Academy, Monroe, Virtual Loudon. These are all great programs. They're providing choice. Well, that's what our school does. It provides choice. And we do it with just objectively and subjectively, just with excellence. And I just would ask of you, please take care of our 143 students the way we take care of the other 80,000. Thank you so much. Thank you. Shelly Norris followed by Kelly

[02:16:10] Pollard. My name is Shelly Norris and I'm the proud mother of Kennedy Norris Kindergarten at HCA.

[02:16:26] Like many others we waited anxiously for Hillsborough Charter Lottery. At 11 p.m. when the house was quiet we watched the recording hearing Kennedy's name called as the 23rd to 24th of the kindergarten class. We cheered quietly overjoyed as HCA's reputation and what it would mean for our family. Tonight I'm here for a teachable moment with Kennedy to show her. Her mom's standing up for what is right. I also listened tonight as Parkview High School was celebrated. A new building, achievements, and accolades while charter schools like HCA are

[02:17:04] often overlooked even though their test scores speak for themselves. When HCA charter was renewed a legal contract was signed that included capital improvements. Change in policy 405410 to exclude the HCA would break that promise. HCA is thriving with a long wait list. Teach the right lesson. Honor your problem. Thank you. Thank you. Kelly Pollard followed by Rob Mutu. Good evening.

[02:17:39] My name is Kelly Pollard and I'm a school social worker and I coach track at Woodgrove High School. I would like to address two points this evening. One is the inadequate number of indoor track coaches and two is the disparity in indoor assistant coaches pay. Participation in indoor track has ballooned over the last several years, resulting in a coaching ratio of approximately one coach to 40 athletes. In no other sport does this exist. That ratio is a serious safety concern and should be addressed by increasing the number of assistant coach positions. Outdoor track has a comparable number of athletes and five coaches. Indoor track assistant coaches are the lowest paid

[02:18:18] coaches in Loudoun County. Assistant coaches in every other sport earn a minimum of \$3,446. assistant coaches in indoor track earn \$1,662 with the same expectations as every other coach thank you for your consideration in addressing both the safety of our athletes and the coaching stipend thank you Rob Mutu followed by Maureen Mutu good evening my name is Rob Mutu I have a first and third grader at Hillsborough Charter Academy and they are thriving my family has farmed

[02:18:56] in Hillsboro since before I was born. While the county has changed so much over those years, small community schools have remained the heartbeat of those communities that they serve. We are incredibly grateful that our local community school is able to offer innovative world-class learning, especially for my kids who are academically high-achieving.

[02:19:16] We are so grateful. Choosing to not support the maintenance of this LCPS-owned facility could be catastrophic for HCA's future. This is a high-achieving and well-accolated school. is more deserving of a showcase status than being at the risk of losing its funding commitment. My children are LCPS students just like non-charter school children, and I'm simply asking you to support them by amending policy 5410 to include HCA and to commit to maintenance of LCPS-owned buildings. Thank you. Thank you. Maureen Mutu, followed by Jeff Morse. Good evening. My name is

[02:19:54] Maureen Mutu, and I'm a full-time organic farmer in Hillsborough. I'm also a proud mom of first and third grader at Hillsboro Charter Academy. I feel so incredibly lucky to have my children at such a unique, innovative, excelling elementary school, but we need the help of the school board to continue Hillsboro Charter's success. I urge you to amend the proposed policy 5410 to allow HCA to have access to capital funds. This funding is essential to keep this amazing neighborhood school operational and my children deserve the same treatment as all other LCBS students. As you all know, schooling is not a one-size-fits-all model. My children are academically ahead and they would not thrive at

[02:20:32] other schools. The supportive small school environment Hillsborough provides allows them to be challenged, provides them specialized curriculum, and helps them continue to love learning. They are not bored at school. You all should be proud of the accomplishments and accolades of Hillsborough and not pass a policy that will hurt it. I strongly believe we need schools like this to continue to meet all the needs of constituencies in a diverse Loudoun County. Thank you. Thank you. Jeff Morse, followed by Katie Collins. Chair Mansfield, Vice Chair Donahue,

[02:21:07] School Board members, and Superintendent Spence, great to see everyone. Twelve years ago this month, I was up on the dais, and I made the motion to approve the charter for M CCS. That motion carried unanimously. There was no partisanship. I'll be honest, at the time, it was a grand experiment.

[02:21:25] But twelve years later, the small school has blossomed. The community staff, and most importantly, The teachers are the reason. HCA and M CCS are fully enrolled with a wait list equal to the number of seats that they have. These students have found a home.

[02:21:41] If I were up there on the dais today, I would be looking to duplicate M CCS, not eliminate it. With enrollment of over 80,000, LCPS does an amazing job meeting the students where they are. That's why you approve the VIEW Academy and RISE Academy.

[02:21:57] And that is why M CCS and HCA belong here. You lose nothing by allowing them to ask for help. Thank you. Thank you. Katie Collins, followed by Kristen Washington. Evening, board members.

[02:22:15] Thank you for all you do for our schools, including our public charter schools. The other day, my six-year-old daughter, a kindergarten scholar at Hillsborough Charter Academy, was playing with her little brother. They had a bunch of play tools out. They're under the table. And she pops out and yells, we're playing engineers.

[02:22:33] To watch my six-year-old daughter be so excited about pretending to be an engineer, being an engineer, and sharing that with her brother was really special. Every day at HCA, she learns that she can be an engineer. Please protect that experience. Please, please keep the funding available for HCA so that they can continue to provide safe and adequate spaces for their students and continue to teach our kids, our LCPS students, that they can be engineers. Thank you.

[02:23:07] Thank you. Kristen Washington followed by Corey Brunet. Dr. Spence, last Thursday I received your email of the LCPS letter. In it you state you are proud to share how your school's working alongside families continue to support every student with the resources, opportunities, and encouragement they need to succeed.

[02:23:29] This has not been my experience. Two of my children are diagnosed dyslexics, one is in seventh grade and I have been fighting for her to get services since the third grade as recently as September 15th and I continually get denied and watch her struggle.

[02:23:54] Her brother is in second grade and has just mastered kindergarten level skills and again I was turned down five times last school year to get support for him. Every student regardless of background or circumstance deserves access to a high quality education that prepares them for success in college career and life i couldn't agree more please make this happen i've spent thousands of dollars on tutors i work three jobs thank you cory brunet followed by michelle mcnaughton good evening my name is cory brunet and i'm an english

[02:24:31] learner teacher at broad run high school i am a member of the union certified collective bargaining team and while i am not allowed to give you specifics i can tell you that lcps and we have reached impasse because we were unable to complete negotiations before October 1st.

[02:24:49] We will continue with a mediator. And as Chris Countryman told you at the last meeting, the union had to file an unfair labor practice against LCPS. The union continues to show up and do the work of negotiating in good faith, representing 12,000 employees. Thank you for your continued commitment and support of LCPS employees. As we often say, educator working conditions are student learning conditions. And as I always say, LCPS will never outperform its

[02:25:21] educators. Thank you. Michelle McNaughton, followed by Kara Van Horn. Good evening. My name is Michelle McNaughton, and I'm the proud parent of a second grader at MCCS. I urge the board to continue to maintain the buildings that you own, including our school. With only two such properties being considered, the cost is minimal. But shifting that burden to the schools would take funds directly from our classrooms, our teachers, and most importantly, our students. Please continue to protect your investments and allow MCCS to focus on what matters most, educating our children. I want to thank the board for their service and consideration in allowing all children in Loudoun

[02:26:01] County to have an engaging and safe community like that at MCCS. Kara Van Horn followed by Keith Townsend. Good evening. When my son was just three and a half months old, a close friend told me about Middleburg Community Charter School with such passion and excitement that I knew it was something special. For four years, I held onto the hope that one day my son would be part of this community.

[02:26:29] Two and a half years ago, that dream became a reality. In that short amount of time, I've watched my son grow not only academically, but as a kind, confident member of our community. MCCS is not just a school, it's a vital thread in the fabric of Middleburg. Local shop owners know our children by name, not because we frequent their stores, but because they actively participate in our classrooms, host field trips, and support hands-on learning experiences. Just last week, our fifth graders practice real world problem solving with local businesses in a way that you simply can't replicate in a textbook. The support MCCS provides to our children extends far beyond academics. It shapes who they are as people. Losing the funding that keeps our school safe and operational would

[02:27:07] jeopardize those opportunities, not just for my family, but for the entire community. Please amend the proposed policy 5410 to allow MCCS to have access to capital funds. Thank you. Keith Townsend followed by Jared Batterman. Hi, good evening. My name is Keith Townsend. You all have a hard job.

[02:27:31] I do not envy your job, but I thank you for what you do. I'm the parent of a second grader at Hillsborough Charter Academy with a rising kindergartner. Thank you for your past support of HCA. My family is proud to be part of LCPS. We're grateful for the opportunity our child has to thrive at such an innovative school. My son loves HCA. He has outstanding teachers. It's clear they pour themselves into their work, their students, we call them scholars. That passion is reflected in the consistently long wait list of families who want the same opportunity for their children. By amending policy 5410 to allow HCA access to capital funds, you ensure our

[02:28:09] children learn in safe, modern facilities, you keep resources focused on classrooms and teachers, and you strengthen the program that is already delivering extraordinary results. HCA has grown

from a small experiment into a proven award-winning school. Amending this policy allows LCPS to build on that success, strengthen the county's reputation for innovative education.

[02:28:31] Thank you. Jared Batterman, followed by Aurora Davis. Hello. My name is Dr. Jared Batterman. I don't use that title a lot because I'm usually not in a space where I consider myself an expert, but my doctorate actually is in communicating information to students with disabilities, primarily those with sensory differences, such as those that are blind and deaf.

[02:28:55] I am a neurodivergent parent of a neurodivergent student that came to MCCS as a selective mute that was so scared of going out in public and being in places with other students that he would often get such intestinal distress that we ended up in the hospital on occasion.

[02:29:16] MCCS has been a godsend for us, and I'm asking you to amend the proposed policy 5410 to allow them to have access to capital funds. I heard a lot in the first part of this meeting about equity and inclusion, diversity and disability. I implore you that if you care about that and want to support your students of your entire county, that you make these changes to help everyone.

[02:29:37] Thank you. Thank you, Aurora Davis, followed by Sophia Bala. Hi, my name is Aurora. I'm a fifth grader at Hillsborough Charter Academy, and I've been going there since kindergarten.

[02:29:56] My experience at HCA has been amazing. I love that we get individual attention to help us grow, like brain-stretching activities, and extra help if we need it. I also love the focus on STEAM because it helps me collaborate with others and makes learning fun. We got to learn about ham radio and even talk to an astronaut on the International Space Station.

[02:30:17] HCA is such a special school. Please don't vote to treat it differently than other LCPS schools. Thank you. Thank you. Sophia Bala followed by Megan Tucker.

[02:30:38] Hello, my name is Sophia Bala. I'm a current freshman at Loudoun Valley High School and I'm a former student of HCA. Hillsborough isn't just a school, It's a family. It shaped me in ways to go far beyond academics. Hillsborough gave me the resources and opportunities to grow as a leader, communicator, and student. Skills I rely on day in and day out.

[02:30:55] One of the most meaningful experiences I had was my passion project. I raised \$5,000 for St. Jude's in colon cancer research. I wasn't just completing a project. I was learning how to connect with people, take initiative, and make a change. I built relationships in my community and took charge.

[02:31:11] This experience made me a negotiator, people person, and help me grow my confidence. Without the resources and flexibility my charter school provided, opportunities like this would simply not exist. Cutting capital funding doesn't just affect a school or a building, it affects each and every student.

[02:31:28] Students like me that thrive in these programs that have shaped and changed us. So please, don't take away our support. We're just as important as the rest. - Thank you. Megan Tucker, followed by Palmer Harnett.

[02:31:51] - Good evening. For the past decade, Hillsborough Charter Academy has been a powerful force for educational excellence in Loudoun County. HCA has earned a remarkable array of accolades in the 10-year time span, including top performance benchmarks and consistent recognition for our innovative, internationally recognized STEAM program.

[02:32:07] HCA is one of the many shining jewels in the crown of LCPS. Our success is the county's success. We are eager to formalize our role, take a seat at your table, partner with the county by sharing our best practices, and maybe be included in the LCPS Innovation and Achievement Report.

[02:32:23] However, to continue this success, we must address a critical need. As tenants of this LCPS facility, we rely on capital planning to maintain essential infrastructure. The air conditioner, the roof, the generator. Without access to necessary capital improvement for funding these major repairs, we face a detrimental financial state.

[02:32:42] Investing in our LCPS facility is investing in our LCPS students. We ask that you think about your choices today and how they will impact the future so we can continue to deliver educational excellence in Loudoun County for years to come. Thank you. Thank you.

[02:32:59] Palmer Harned, followed by Emilia Lupino Esposito. Good evening. I'm the mother of a first grader at Hillsborough Charter. I want to highlight the opportunity the county has to benefit from HCA.

[02:33:17] The demand for their teaching model grows in our community every year. My son comes home from school with new ideas and inspirations every day as a direct result of their unique approach to learning. And since it's a public charter, it's open to everyone in LCPS.

[02:33:34] There's no tuition or application. The only difference is it has the flexibility to enhance kids' learning. That's such a unique benefit to the community. And the demand really speaks for itself because the wait list is so long and shows the need for an expansion in resources, if anything.

[02:33:50] Ultimately, this is an LCPS-owned building, and these amazing LCPS students deserve the same funding as all the others. Thank you. Thank you. Ayla Lupina Esposito, followed by Patricia Keen.

[02:34:11] My name is Amelia Lupina Esposito, and I'm in fifth grade at HCA. I've been going to HCA since kindergarten. Our school is innovative and has a great STEAM program.

[02:34:29] We have wonderful teachers and wonderful classes, and we're in so many different things. Our school building is not like the other schools here. It is very old. We have our music room on the stage. Our art cottage is not inside our building. Our gym is very small and is also our cafeteria and auditorium.

[02:34:47] Our PE teacher has an office that is actually a closet. The school board should keep giving HCA funding to make big repairs if there is a problem with the school. Everyone at HCA loves the school and wants it to stay open for a long time. Please vote to keep all of the funding for HCA.

[02:35:02] Thank you. Thank you. Patricia Keene, followed by Sheena Custer. Oh, I'm sorry. Ayla Lupina Esposito, followed by Patricia Keene.

[02:35:24] Hi, my name's Anna, and I'm in first grade, and I like art because we get to draw pinch pot monsters, and we get to paint and cover, and I also like music because we get to collaborate in sounds, and I like my story at kindergarten when I couldn't meet any friends, and then I met two, and then they were my favorite friends.

[02:35:54] Thank you. Okay, Patricia Keene, followed by Sheena Custer. Hello, thank you for allowing us to speak.

[02:36:15] When we moved to Virginia 10 years ago, we knew we'd be in public schools for a long time. We have 11 more years to go. We were looking for the best education, and all research showed Loudoun was a

great choice. I still believe, through all the struggles that Loudoun has had in the last 10 years, it is the best choice.

[02:36:31] I have found with four children in now four different schools in Loudoun that our school system has so much to offer. A quick search brings up multiple programs including International Maclurea, Dual Language Immersion, the Academies, ROTC, Transition Center for Students with Disabilities, to name a few.

[02:36:49] When I started researching our options for alternative learning at the grade school level, I found the charters as another great option. I also found a very long waitlist. As my family remained on the waitlist for five years, I quietly followed the innovation at Hillsborough.

[02:37:04] I saw the want for this specific education model grow. I spoke with friends in the community about how the students learn and excel. I waited. I wonder if it was worth the drive from Ashburn. It was worth the drive. It's worth the funding. Thank you. Sheena Custer, followed by Katie Sharnley.

[02:37:28] Good evening. I am a teacher and proud parent at MCCS. I want to invite you to our school. Let me tell you why. we design learning experiences that reflect student passions think of third graders using photography to show how they are active community members our scholars are engaged think of our fifth graders who partnered with business owners to practice real life conflict resolution skills we also value assessment our scores are high and competitive but we are playing the long game

[02:38:06] of education. MCCS fosters lifelong learning, which means we never stop reflecting and responding. At the heart of MCCS is student-centered learning. Does this sound familiar? We have been implementing the LCPS instructional framework for years. MCCS is a living model of the framework in action. We hope you can consider this when discussing the action item, and we hope you visit

[02:38:32] MCCS soon. Thank you. Katie Charnley followed by Jessica Ellinger. Good evening. I'm Katie Charnley, assistant principal at Middleburg Community Charter School, a beloved 100-year-old cornerstone. Did you know that LCPS is home to two of the seven public charters throughout the entire state of Virginia? I'm here tonight to ask you to keep those two charters in the CIP because what we have is truly special. I serve the Middleburg community as a teacher, curriculum

[02:39:10] specialist, dean, and now assistant principal. I've watched students and entire families grow and thrive within our walls. We bring learning to life through multiple initiatives, including our health system, which some of you are a part of, Dr. Rashid and Curiasita, and Dr. Spence and Somato. Most recently, we've been recognized nationally for our community engagement, but our building is aging. Without continued investment, we risk losing the safe and inspiring environment our children deserve. Please keep MCCS and HCA in the CIP. Support us and you're preserving more than a building. You're investing in a thriving community. Thank you and please come

[02:39:47] visit. Thank you. Jessica Ellinger followed by Alejandra Boswell. Good evening. My name is Jessica Ellinger. I'm the parent of an LCPS graduate and three current LCPS students as well as being an LCPS middle school math teacher. All four of my children attended HCA and I'm here tonight to urge you to honor your commitment and continue capital funding for the charters. I could talk for hours about the amazing educational experiences my LCPS students had at HCA with their LCPS teachers, but I will focus my comments on my oldest daughter, Sophia. She attended HCA and the

[02:40:26] entrepreneurship program at AET, both STEAM-focused special programs within LCPS. AET is fully funded with beautiful facilities and amazing instructional resources. HCA was not, holding music class on the stage and PE in the cafeteria while still managing to provide incredible educational experiences. That is not equity and LCPS students at HCA deserve to have an equitable experience to every other LCPS student. Please continue to fund capital improvements so that HCA can use their per pupil funds for instruction and not roof repair. Thank you. Thank you. Alejandra Boswell

[02:41:04] followed by Corey Phillips. Good evening. I'm a tax-paying Loudoun County homeowner and the parent of a second grader at Middleburg Community Charter School. My daughter loves her school. She is thriving, supported, and part of a true community that feels like family.

[02:41:21] If you stepped inside MCCC, you would feel it instantly. Charter schools are county schools with county employees. LCPS states as a top priority that they want to create a sense of belonging for every student and that they're committed to fostering an environment where educators feel valued, supported, and empowered to excel.

[02:41:38] Removing capital funds denies county children, school facilities, and equipment that make these goals possible. Strong schools like MCCC make strong communities with families who want to stay here, invest here, and grow here. Equitable funding ensures every county child has the resources they need to thrive.

[02:41:56] Being a voice and advocate for my child is the line I will always stand firm on. And as school board members, I assume your stand must be the same. To put children first, always. Thank you. Thank you.

[02:42:12] Corey Phillips, followed by Wendy McKenna. Good evening. My name is Corey Phillips. I'm here asking you as a 10-year Loudoun County resident, business owner, and most importantly as a parent, to amend the proposed policy 5410 so that my kid's school, HCA, can access capital funds like all the other Loudoun County public schools.

[02:42:40] Now more than ever, we need a school like HCA and the other charter schools in our county. When my son started kindergarten, was quickly introduced to the engineering design process, which at the time seemed quite astonishing to me. For those like me who are less familiar with it, it provides a problem-solving framework broken down into five steps. Ask, explore, model, evaluate, and explain. He is now in fifth grade, and I cannot count the number of times he and his sister have used the engineering design process and applied it to everything from science to art to even random questions he comes up with on his own. In a world overloaded with information and influencers, HCA has prepared him to be a

[02:43:18] critical thinker. We are asking you to keep your promise to include charter schools like HCA in consideration for funding like all other Loudoun County public schools. Thank you. Wendy McKenna followed by Gary Higgins.

[02:43:47] Good evening. I want to start out by saying hearing my name that I'm next my heart starts beating fast. My voice is going to be shaky and I think of all of these scholars sitting behind me that are coming up here, and they're so strong. I wish I had had a Hillsborough Charter Academy to teach me to stand up here and public speak without my heart racing and my voice shaking. I am here to ask that you honor the agreement that you all made just last year with Hillsborough Charter Academy. I have been

fortunate to have all of my children attend HCA. I went from a mom that was nervous to send her first child to elementary school to a mom that stands here today,

[02:44:26] sad that my journey at HCA will end. I am forever grateful to LCPS for saying yes to charter schools. This yes has helped my children feel seen, respected, and respectful of others. They are now curious scholars with a wonderful start on their educational journey with LCPS. As an example of capital funds needed, how could you expect a charter school to replace their HVAC? We want that money

[02:44:52] to go. Thank you. Gary Higgins, followed by Ashley Bartsch. Thank you, Madam Chair, members of the board. I'm here tonight to encourage you to amend the proposed policy 5410 to ensure that HCA and Middleburg Charter Academy children and schools are included in the capital funding. Loudoun's

[02:45:23] motto was climate for success, and these charter schools create a climate for success. In fact, they're not much different than the academies of Loudoun in the way that it creates a climate for success for specialized students with specialized needs. All the other children in Loudoun County public schools are covered under the CIP no matter what facility they're in, and there's no reason why these shouldn't be either. Loudoun County should be encouraging these charter schools rather than depriving them of CIP funding.

[02:46:01] I would add also that at the time that these were created, it was a bipartisan effort from both boards and funded by the Board of Supervisors through Loudoun County Public Schools. Thank you. Dario, let's see, Ashley Birch, followed by Dario Barini.

[02:46:24] Good evening, board members. My name is Ashley Birch. I'm a lifelong Loudoun resident and LCPS graduate and now a parent of students at Hillsborough Charter Academy. I'm deeply connected and committed to public education here. I'm also incredibly proud to be a part of the innovative charter community.

[02:46:43] My children thrive in this specialized environment our school provides. Just last year, they were given the incredible opportunity to make amateur radio contact with astronaut Sunita Williams on the International Space Station. Students from every grade were able to speak and ask her questions real time and receive responses over the radio.

[02:46:58] This opportunity will be talked about in our family for generations to come. And this is one example of the hands-on learning this school provides. Every student attending the two affected public charter schools deserve the same commitment to a safe, functional learning space as any other LCPS student. This funding ensures we can maintain essential infrastructure and necessary renovations.

[02:47:18] Charter schools are public schools. Their students are your constituents. I respectfully urge you to reject any proposal and policy change to 5410 that strips away any equitable access to funding. Thank you. Thank you. Dario Barini, followed by Joe Lupino Esposito.

[02:47:43] Good evening. Members of the board, thank you for your time. I come here before the board in many capacities as a student parent, part of the Middleburg Charter community, and a proud Loudoun County Public School alumnus. You heard a lot tonight about the impact the charter schools have had on students and their families.

[02:47:59] It's undeniable that these schools have made a tremendous difference in all of their lives, but I'm not here to speak on behalf of any of them. You've heard their stories for yourself. Instead, I came tonight to speak for the students that are yet to come. This is more than a financial decision.

[02:48:14] It's a missed opportunity. Loudoun has and will continue to be at the forefront of innovation. It's part of what brings so many people to Loudoun in the first place. And instead of living up to that reputation, at the moment when families are asking for more choices, with hundreds of students on charter wait lists, the school board is instead signaling that Loudoun is not interested in education innovation.

[02:48:35] Instead of a vote tonight on the charter amendment, I implore this board to table this vote and consider how charter schools can be further developed and expanded in the county. We should be leaning into innovation and not stepping away from it. Thank you. Joe Lupino Esposito, followed by Stephen Robinson.

[02:48:56] You heard from my kids earlier, and they're cute, but I am not going to be cute with all of you. I just want to be very clear. Some things that you've heard over the years regarding the charter schools and the history, Jeff Morse alluded to some of that earlier, it's just a little bit inaccurate.

[02:49:11] But what's really more important now, even if that were 100% true, you have a problem here. You've heard from everybody tonight. These schools cannot just simply go away. They can't be dissolved. They can't be just dispersing the kids out into the rest of the schools, into more overcrowded classrooms. It's not an option that you have.

[02:49:27] Instead, you do have a great choice. You have one choice to violate the contract that we signed with you all just a year ago and upset all the parents here and, as the last speaker said, upset generations to come. Or, I think this is a no-brainer, the other choice, honor the contract, agree to do an amendment tonight, and continue to support the charter schools as you have done in the past.

[02:49:48] It's an important thing to do, and it's an important step to move forward with LCPS and our communities all together as one. Let's have a time for a new agreement where we can all get together and really thrive together as a community. So thank you. Stephen Robinson.

[02:50:08] All right, good evening. I've got to say real quick, I'm just so proud to be a principal here at MCCS, seeing all of our staff, our families who are out here advocating for our school. I came in 2019, and I can say I am proud to serve our community.

[02:50:27] The purpose of MCCS, since I came in here, has to promote our scholars of character who are curious, confident, and love to learn, and definitely in a school that our scholars love. If you come to MCCS, you will see that firsthand. Our scholars truly love our school.

[02:50:44] I'm sure this thing you said for also HCA, I know Paul is doing a phenomenal job over there at Hillsboro. For 10 years, we've embodied this purpose and provided families with an alternative opportunity for their scholars. I'm happy to serve and see a vibrant community that is so diverse and serves college all across the county, not just in Middleburg.

[02:51:05] I ask that the LCPS board consider to revise the amendment to allow us to definitely have that opportunity with the CIP and serve scholars for years to come. Thank you so much. Thank you. All right.

With that, public comment is now over, and we will take a short recess, And we will reconvene at 8, 10 p.m.

[02:51:35] The board is now in recess.

[03:04:27] Okay, the board is coming out of recess. And we will continue with item 10 in our action item, starting with 10.01 that we have moved from our consent agenda.

[03:04:45] It's the Office of the Superintendent, LGBTQ Plus History Month. Before we make a motion, Ms. Chandler, would you please read the proclamation so that the board members will know what it says. Yes, Madam Chair, thank you. This proclamation is LGBTQ plus History Month, October 2025, whereas LGBTQ plus History Month, founded in 1994 by educator Rodney Wilson, honors the history, achievements, and contributions of lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer people.

[03:05:15] And whereas this observance provides an opportunity to celebrate the strength, resilience, and impact of the LGBTQ community whose contributions have enriched the cultural, educational, and civic life of Virginia and the world.

[03:05:31] And, whereas, during LGBTQ Plus History Month, including National Coming Out Day on October 11th, we celebrate key figures and milestones, knowing that education is the most powerful tool to promote understanding and disrupt discrimination.

[03:05:51] Whereas Loudoun County Public Schools is committed to fostering equity and belonging, ensuring every student and staff member is welcomed into a safe, supportive, inclusive, and affirming environment.

[03:06:06] And whereas we reject discrimination based on gender identity, sexual orientation, and gender expression, and instead affirm kindness, acceptance, and respect as the foundation of our learning community. and whereas our school division is stronger when every student and staff member can live authentically and fills a true sense of belonging and when we embrace the full diversity of our community which empowered 96.6 of all students in Loudoun County Public Schools to graduate in 2025

[03:06:42] and whereas Loudoun County Public Schools continues to build strong partnerships with individuals and organizations to promote understanding and celebrate diversity and cultivate inclusive practices that support all students and families and now therefore be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board recognizes October 2025 as LGBTQ Plus History Month in Loudoun County Public Schools and encourages staff, students, and the community to honor and celebrate the rich history and contributions of the LGBTQ plus community to the

[03:07:22] Commonwealth of Virginia, our beautifully diverse county, and our schools during LGBTQ plus history month and throughout the school year. Thank you, Ms. Chandler. Would you please, at this time, I'll go ahead and entertain a motion. Yes, Vice Chair Donahue. I move that the Loudoun County School Board approved the proclamation for LGBTQ History Month for October 2025.

[03:07:49] Thank you. I have a motion by Vice Chair Donahue. Do I have a second? Second. I have a second by Ms. Chandler. It's been properly moved and seconded. Is there any further discussion? Yes, Mrs. Griffiths. Thank you, Madam Chair. I want to be clear that I did not vote for this proclamation last year and will not vote for this proclamation tonight.

[03:08:09] There is a meaningful difference between formally recognizing a group in history and promoting that group for its lifestyle to our students. It crosses the line into advocacy and raises serious concerns under the executive order on protecting our children from inappropriate content in our schools.

[03:08:27] Our communications must remain age appropriate and leave conversations about sensitive information to parents. Schools exist to teach children how to read, write, and think critically, not engage them in conversations about sexuality at any age when they are far too young to process it.

[03:08:45] I have been contacted by many constituents that newsletters have been going out to the parents, starting at the elementary school level. It really bothers most parents in Loudoun County. They think it is not age appropriate. So I will not be voting for this tonight.

[03:09:01] Thank you. - Is there any other discussion? Seeing none, we will go ahead and move forward with the vote. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please, well, I'll wait.

[03:09:17] Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote? Yes. Clerk, please close and display the vote. That motion passes 6-3 with Mrs. Griffiths, Ms. Chernoff, and Ms. LaBelle in opposition to the vote.

[03:09:41] We'll move on to item 10.02, Department of Business and Financial Services School Board Calendar for the Development of the Fiscal 2027 Budget, presented by Sharon Willoughby, Chief Financial Officer. actually first do i do i have a motion okay yeah yeah go ahead uh vice chair donoghue sorry thank you uh thank you madam chair i move that the loudon county school board adopt the proposed

[03:10:21] budget development calendar for the fy 27 um budget um i have a motion by vice chair donoghue do i have a second. I have a second by Mr. Streffi. Is there any discussion? Yes, Ms. Chernoff.

[03:10:36] Thank you, Madam Chair. As I discussed last meeting, I'm going to make a motion that would potentially move the public hearing because the public hearing as it stands now is the same day as the budget adoption, which in my opinion defeats the purpose since all of our proposed amendments have to be submitted to staff by noon that Monday and then the public would come and tell us what they want us to change in the budget when that decision has already been made things can happen on the fly but that puts us in a little bit of a frantic situation so that is why i will make

[03:11:15] the following motion i move to move the public hearing from tuesday february 3rd 2026 to january 29th 2026 this will also make the january 29th meeting mandatory and no longer optional thank - Thank you, Ms. Chernoff.

[03:11:32] We have a motion on the floor. Do I have a second? - I have a second by Ms. LaBelle. Is there any discussion? Yes, Vice-Chair Donahue. - Thank you, Madam Chair. Just a question for clarification. January 29th is, 2026 is a Thursday, so that would be a Thursday meeting when we would have the fourth Tuesday school board meeting on the 27th, the budget meeting on the 29th, and then the budget meeting on Tuesday, February 3rd.

[03:12:07] sure enough would you like to answer that that is correct currently we have a meeting that is tentative optional if necessary thursday january 29th 2026 anyway and knowing this board we usually take those opportunities so i'm gonna say we'll probably have the meeting anyway because there'll be some overflow questions about the budget process but that would take that meeting away from being if

necessary to being a mandatory meeting for us any other discussion we can vote on Ms. Chernoff's amendment.

[03:12:42] Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote? Yes.

[03:12:59] Clerk, would you please close and display the vote? And that motion passes. Eight with Jeremy Asfield abstaining for the vote. Okay. And then we need to go ahead and vote on the motion as amended.

[03:13:22] So is there any discussion? No? Okay. Let's go ahead and vote. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote?

[03:13:40] Yes. Clerk, would you please close and display the vote? And that motion passes. Eight with Chair Mansfield abstaining for the vote. Okay, we will move on to Specialized Programs and Centers Committee Review of Policy 5410.

[03:13:58] Dr. Rasheed, would you, do you have a motion? Yes, I do have a motion. And my motion is to have policy 5410.

[03:14:17] Yeah, I would like to just defer to Ms. Ray Mitchell about this item. Just to describe the description of it. We normally use that for discussion time is when we talk about it, but I'll go ahead and allow it this time.

[03:14:35] Okay, thank you. Good evening, school board members. Policy 5410, establishment of charter schools went before the specialized programs and centers committee as an information item on August 5th, and then was taken as an action item to that committee on September 2nd, 2025, and then came before the school board at our last meeting as an information item, and we are here again tonight with the policy and the red line version as an action item.

[03:15:08] Thank you. Our normal course of action is to go ahead and make a motion and then we discuss it and then we can have some more discussion.

[03:15:26] Thank you, Chair. It's been a busy time at SPCC, as you can see, and we heard a lot in public comment. This item was reviewed by SPCC earlier in the month and now it's brought for review of action today. I definitely would like to propose to have policy 5410 approved, the changes of it approved.

[03:15:50] However, personally, as my vote, I will be approving the amendments that are presented. So that's why I had some confusion about that. Right, that's fine. But first make the motion. Yes, sure. Because you're the chair. Thank you, Chair. I move that the Loudoun County School Board adopt SPCC's approved changes to policy 5410, establishment of charter schools.

[03:16:11] I have a motion. Do I have a second? Second. I have a second by Vice Chair Donahue. Now, do I have any discussion? Yes, Dr. Rasheed. It's been a busy time at SPCC. I keep repeating myself, but I have been so happy to learn about the great experiences students are having at HCA that they're having at MCCS as well.

[03:16:32] Parents have shared with me how much their children benefit from their time at these schools and that it's so important to me as a school board member, as the special programs chair, and as a parent myself. We know that it's been the standard to exclude charter schools from LCPS Capital Improvement Plan, and this was intentional when Loudoun charter schools were created under previous school boards.

[03:16:53] In fact, as we have discussed, policy and agreements for HCA and MCCA have stated that LCPS has no obligation to include these schools in the CIP. Perhaps this verbiage is not clear enough or leaves too much room for different interpretations.

[03:17:10] Therefore, I do support creating more direct and clearer wording for this policy going forward while allowing for CIP consideration for the two existing charter schools in our country, in our county. However, any charter schools formed in the future in Loudoun should truly embrace the independent spirit of charter schools.

[03:17:29] Virginia Code and VDOE guidance on charter schools states that charters are responsible for their own budgeting and other financial planning. And that should be clearly stated for any charter schools going forward. Thank you, Chair. Thank you, Dr. Rasheed.

[03:17:46] To that, I would like to make an amendment before we start off the amendments. Because I feel that the policy 5410 with the title establishment of charter schools is not exactly what this policy is. It's not only the establishment of, but it's also, there's also in here on section H is renewal of application and then section I is revocation.

[03:18:11] So it really should just be, I would delete establishment of and just have charter schools to be the thing. So that's going to be my first amendment. Do I have a second? I have a second by dot. Mr. Estruffy. Is there any discussion about that particular amendment? No. Okay. We'll go ahead and vote. Okay. Well, let's do this amendment and do the title and then we can do the rest.

[03:18:46] Yes, but let's vote. The amendment is just to, would you please open the vote? Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote? Yes. Okay. Clerk, would you please close and display the vote? And that motion passes eight to one with Mrs.

[03:19:10] Griffiths in opposition okay now let's go back we can have an amendment we'll go back and let's go ahead and vote on that as a part of the first and then we'll go ahead and do the amendments because I know there's a couple okay if we could vote on the amendment the base motion as amended okay any discussion on that clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote so we have the

[03:19:46] first amendment right just to change the title and now we have to put that into the base motion vote on it as a base vote the amendment that we just passed voted into the base motion like we did with committees can you restate the base motion base motion well the base motion was the Loudoun County School Board adopt the specialized programs and centers committee approved changes to

[03:20:16] policy 5410 establishment of charter schools well any other discussion or confusion um my previous vote about establishment i did not want that word taken out because that would effectively say we do not establish any further no that's not what it means well that's what i got from it and i voted no because that's what i got when you take away the word establishment

[03:20:47] it just says charter schools now well i don't know if it makes a difference to go back and fix that but taking away that word made me feel like it was no more establishing new schools well you can now vote to approve it and then that would be into the base the base motion okay I'll go ahead and do that then thanks okay clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote dr. Deans would you please state your

[03:21:22] vote yes okay clerk please close and display the vote that motion passes with miss Donahue abstaining for the vote okay now we're at the base motion as amended? Is there any discussion? Yes, Ms. Chernoff. Thank you, Madam Chair. I have apologies to the crowd that have seen my amendments online. I have had to tweak them a bit given this new amendment and information, so actually condensing them down into one amendment. So I'm going to move that on

[03:22:00] the red line version that we replace lines 285 and 286 with the following language. A charter school facility or campus will not be included in the school board's capital improvement program which includes its capital asset prevention program cap for current or future capital improvements unless the school board deems it necessary to do so in addition the school board will defer to the current charter agreements for existing charter schools second i got a motion uh an amendment and And now I have a second by Vice Chair Donahue.

[03:22:39] Ms. Chernoff, would you please say it again? Which includes its capital upset preservation program for current or future capital improvements unless the school board deems it necessary to do so. In addition, the school board will defer to the current charter agreements for existing charter schools.

[03:23:04] And that was from your second amendment. Okay, thanks. Okay, is there any discussion? Yes, Ms. LaBelle. I'm so glad you're back next to me.

[03:23:21] I have sat here tonight and I have listened to 47 people in our school community speak to the merits of having charter schools in our community. However, there are some people that I have heard from that say that it's not so.

[03:23:41] So I'm going to take their comments and respond. People say we shouldn't do this because it's in the contract that we shouldn't have to. The current contract and policy states that requests must be considered.

[03:23:57] After speaking with Jeff Morse, a member of the LCPS school board whom you've heard from tonight, when the charter schools were first established, he said his board welcomed the idea of charter schools, but in order to be fiscally cautious, they limited the expenditures on the building until the schools could prove their worth.

[03:24:17] It was expected that if successful, the schools could renegotiate the contract. Well, both charter schools have proven their worth. One has only to look at their academic scores and rankings in state and national surveys. Middleburg scored an average eight points higher than this district in math, 71 to 63, and four points higher in reading, 66 to 62, for the initial wanting to attend due to their innovative and creative instructional programs for curriculums.

[03:24:52] We should not be limiting them, but rather asking what they are doing that could be shared with our other elementary schools, particularly our Title I schools. Second reason why we shouldn't be spending taxpayer money on these schools.

[03:25:08] Well, many schools are funded with taxpayer money through LCPS Special Programs and Centers. Being a member of that committee, I know exactly what they are. The North Star School, the Recovery School, the Access Academy, the International Baccalaureate Programs, the Dual Language Immersion Programs, the Navy Junior Reserved Officer Training Program, the Virtual Distance Learning Program, Virtual Loudon Online, the Academies of Loudon, including the Academy of Science and

Academy of Engineering and Technology and the Monroe Advanced Technology Academy under their umbrella.

[03:25:45] and the Thomas Jefferson High School, which cost our taxpayers upwards of \$12 million annually for tuition and transportation. Loudoun taxpayer money goes into funding Fairfax Public Schools pockets. New and upcoming special centers and programs also include the Transition Center, which we approved last year and will be naming, and the Global Linguistics Program.

[03:26:12] And lastly, in all senses of the word, are our two charter schools, the Hillsborough Charter Academy and the Middleburg Community Charter Schools, the only schools that will be barred from receiving CIP and CAPP money.

[03:26:28] Why? These two schools serve LCPS students, are staffed primarily by LCPS staff, and are housed in LCPS-owned buildings policies of LCPS School Board, even though they are not required to do so.

[03:26:48] They report grades and attendance to LCPS by State Law Code 22.1-212.6. They are required to name a management committee who will be responsible for its own operations, including but not limited to budget preparation, contract for service permitted to charge tuition.

[03:27:13] Their budget must be met by per-pupil funding given to the county by the state. Each school is required by law to comply with the requirements of the standards of quality, including the standards of learning and the standards of accreditation, again, code 22.1-212.6.

[03:27:34] They are excluded from LCPS transportation and have to contract and pay for their very own limited bus services through public entities and depend on parent participation for the rest of their transportation needs. They are the only schools of our special programs and centers that don't receive LCPS transportation services.

[03:27:59] And the third reason I hear a lot, charter schools don't have special ed program services. Charter schools, by federal law, are required to have special education services. Both Hillsborough and Middleburg have special ed students enrolled in their schools.

[03:28:15] They are accepted into the schools by the same process as all other schools. lottery process. No child is rejected nor given priority over any other child. All applicants are included in the process and no child is turned away due to disability, religion, sex, gender, or cultural background. Students with IEPs are given the same accommodations and services such as speech therapy, physical therapy, occupational therapy, etc. that they would receive in their regular public school. Goals are met, documented, and reported. IEPs are written,

[03:28:53] updated, or revised as needed in the same manner as all other LCPS and IEPs in the county through LCPS Student Services Department. In conclusion, to limit or restrict options that support our charter schools sends the message to all these people sitting here today that their input is not valued. This is not a good look for LCPS schools. I encourage you to consider accepting Ms. Chernoff's

[03:29:26] newest amendment. Thank you. Thank you, Ms. LaBelle. Mr. Lewis, I know that the original agreements had contemplated that the charter school organization would be responsible for all maintenance and capital improvements. Could you give us a little bit more understanding of the history of

this and what exactly we're supposed to be responsible for and what was contemplated and what a risk there

[03:30:03] might be sure thank you chair Mansfield so the I guess the easiest way to describe this is there are three governing documents for both of the charter schools and so we have the policy and then we have the agreement and the agreement is the document that the charter school promises to set up a school and how they teach children and all the different things that are coming about how they run the school then there's the lease that we have established for both of the buildings separately they are both very similar in language and the both of those documents and specifically speaking about HCA

[03:30:37] because I have the dates in my head the agreement was changed in the summer of and I think it was June of 2024 that added the reference to that school boards could consider the buildings in the CIP however the agreement or the lease I mean has in both cases specific language in six different references in the document where the capital improvements are the sole responsibility of the charter school and those references are still in that document even though it was revised to include the fact that the school board

[03:31:15] may consider that so right now the the charter school agree or the leases both require this the charter schools to be responsible for their capital improvements. And so that is one of the things that we were trying to clear up in these changes to the policy is to align all three of these documents because right now they are not perfectly aligned. And it does say, you know, so we have, you know, whether or not we make changes to an agreement before the policy and this board has, you know, had that conversation in the past about which one do you do first. So we were attempting to make an alignment between those documents with

[03:31:48] the changes to this policy. So moving forward, the risk you have is these buildings are old and you heard a number of comments about that tonight they both are in need of future capital capital repairs but also we've had conversations about capital expansions and so those come with them a risk for the school board you know from a building code perspective once you begin working on a building you may be required to do other things both of the buildings in the leases that are still language in the lease that says both of those buildings were accepted by the

[03:32:24] board of directors from the charter schools and then as is where is condition so and there were specific references to that they were also taking responsibility for all a DA compliance if the school board accepts those projects and starts to do capital improvements we may then be have to upgrade the entire building both of those buildings to meet modern code compliances an existing building doesn't necessarily have to be upgraded if you can still have access to programs for students and so you know you know as as our buildings were built over a hundred year period not all of

[03:33:01] them have the same features in them so if we were to embark on those changes we may be required to completely remodel both of those buildings which is not really feasible in some cases so that's the risk this board takes by including those without any restrictions on that is you may be required to you know do a you know tens of millions of dollars worth of renovations to that the additional risk is to that is we're going to begin the conversation about the capital budget in a couple of weeks and you're going to see all 100 schools and

[03:33:37] how we plan to renovate those over time and so these if the board wants to do that then these would have to be fit in to that also share that in keeping with language that was changed in June of last

year that said the school board would consider any changes to the requests to the charter schools we did a staff come to the board during the capital budget saying and make sure that you were aware that we had no capital budget projects in the CIP for FY 26 it would be anticipated that's the same thing you'll see in a few weeks on we

[03:34:15] are not bringing that and the board voted to continue with the CIP adopt the CIP without any projects there and specifically you excluded projects for playgrounds in the CIP for last year so there are a number of things that are at risk for the board and things that may not be perfectly clear now at some point in time we need to you know reconcile the fact that the boards of directors both accepted those buildings as is where is and accepted and made the commitment to maintain those buildings which now the boards being asked the

[03:34:49] the school board is being asked to do yes miss chandler thank you madam chair um thank you mr lewis um and thank you miss mitchell i i always have to start with the from the place of understanding what happened in the past and i i want to thank you for reiterating that for us um contextually i just want to um reaffirm that at the time the lcps or and the loudon county school board entered into contracts with both of the charter schools that we serve we had decided that the buildings

[03:35:28] were no longer serving our purposes and we were offering those schools as is to the entity the charter school and that they would take on financial responsibility for those entities as is i have a couple more questions if that's okay that is correct that's how the original documents were formed okay um thank you mr lewis and um this question is uh really for miss mitchell although dr ellis certainly whoever is best appropriate to me from a management structure what makes

[03:36:04] these two charter schools different from any of the list of other specialized programs that we serve through our specialized program program could you give me a little bit more are you meaning in terms of how it's decided if there is a program at the charter schools versus not how it's decided but in the day-to-day management of the charter schools who is ultimately responsible for making day-to-day decisions so the principals of those two charter schools which are not lcps staff as the teachers are so those two principals are hired by the boards

[03:36:41] the individual boards of each of the charter schools and they are responsible for the day-to-day management the charter schools create their own calendar of number of days that they go they do not follow the same instructional calendar that we do so they make those decisions they do they are supported our elementary office does support them with questions and guidance and things of sharing resources but ultimately those two building leaders are responsible thank you for that clarification so as a follow-up if there were a crisis situation or a decision that was

[03:37:19] a high-level decision that was made the principal and the charter school board would be responsible for that as opposed to the administration of lcps and the school board that is correct okay thank you and then um just we certainly have engaged in this conversation over the past couple years One of, I represent Algonquian District.

[03:37:42] I am on the far eastern side of Loudoun County. And one of the things that I struggle with, most of the population in Loudoun County lives in the east now. It's about 85%, right? I think you guys are doing great work. It's not a reflection of that, but it's not accessible to everybody in the county.

[03:38:03] And I don't know how we make accessible. I'm not sure if anybody's talked about moving into Leesburg, maybe giving up some of that autonomy and coming back into the LCPS model. But for me personally, I'm not inclined to engage in this conversation.

[03:38:21] I feel like we made an agreement. The agreement stands. The agreement has to stand. And one thing that I really struggle to understand when I look at your dashboard, just as of yesterday, for Hillsborough, the population is 83% white.

[03:38:38] They serve zero EL students. There are 5.6% students who are economically disadvantaged and 8.4% with an IEP. At Middleburg, it looks a little different. I'll give you that. It's 65.8% white, only 2.7% EL, 0% economically disadvantaged, and 10.7% with an IEP.

[03:39:03] I don't understand exactly why, but it's a hesitation that I personally feel, so I will not be supporting the amendment. Thank you, Ms. Chandler. Mrs. Griffiths? No. Dr. Deans, I'll call on you after Mrs. Griffiths, okay?

[03:39:20] Thank you. Thank you, Madam Chair. First of all, I just want to say it gave me chills down my spine today to listen to a lot of these parents. Mr. Morse is here, former Loudoun County School Board member and board member to Middleburg Charter, who was here for all the history of the charter schools, which he said today was an experiment, an experiment that was successful.

[03:39:45] So I want to thank Mr. Morse for being a part of that. With that experiment, I'm guessing we weren't sure, with the history, how successful these schools would be. So I honestly don't know how the vote will go today.

[03:40:03] And forgive me for getting a little bit nervous when I heard the word established taken out. Because I'm hoping, because these two schools were so successful, I'm hoping we can have more. or actually do a pilot charter school, possibly in Sterling, which is not far from your area, Ms. Chandler, and do a pilot program and compare it to our Title I schools.

[03:40:32] I think that would be a great idea. So I am all for funding the CIP program for the charter schools, and I just want to be clear about that. I think if we vote against funding Hillsboro and Middleburg, it would profoundly hurt Loudoun County.

[03:40:53] All CPS buildings should be maintained to current compliance levels, making sure our students are safe. It is standard stewardship of the taxpayer investment. This school is a vital part of this community and a lifeline for our students.

[03:41:11] Families choose this school because it meets the unique needs of their students and it has become a place where children feel safe, supported, and inspired to learn. By removing charter schools from the capital improvement program and placing all responsibility for repairs and safety solely on them, the district risks undermining the very foundation of what makes our schools and communities thrive.

[03:41:36] When resources must be diverted to cover large facility costs without district support, it takes away from classrooms, teachers, and student programs the very things that help our children succeed. Middleburg Charter and Hillsboro are two of only seven charter schools that we employ LCPS certified teachers shows our continued commitment to the LCPS model of educational excellence. Combined with unique curriculums, our teachers

[03:42:10] create a tailored learning environment that has enabled our Middleburg and Hillsboro students to thrive academically and socially. Changes to the contracts would make Middleburg and Hillsboro the only two public educational facilities in the county that are not supported in the capital improvement program. I ask you, what kind of message does this send? I know that Hillsboro, I know personally, I visited Hillsboro. I know personally that they had to fundraise to get a new roof. I've also seen the bathrooms there that are not ADA compliant. I am in full support of our

[03:42:46] charter schools and choice for parents on where to send their children. If we can spend \$200,000 per school to change the names of schools on the outsides of schools, we could have used that money to help fund our charter schools. It's a small amount, but as opposed to what they need, renaming of schools was just an absurd thing to do. We sent the wrong message. Again, I support our charter schools, and I want to apologize for that first vote. Thank you. Dr. Deans?

[03:43:18] My statements are around the same question that I've asked Mr. Lewis repeatedly. Can Loudoun County public schools absorb the 288 students that are in the two charter schools and not be overcrowded?

[03:43:45] That's a question for Mr. Lewis. She wants to know, I think it's probably more like 300, it's like 140 each or something like that. She wants to know if our other schools can absorb those students. Yes, ma'am, there are available seats for all those students. 280.

[03:44:01] Yes, ma'am, there are available seats for those students. Okay. If there are available seats for those students, then the same resources that have been poured into the charter schools can be poured into other elementary schools, and the result could be the same, rather than to clobber off the best of the crop and put them in the charter schools.

[03:44:34] It is my belief that we need to focus on the 100 schools that we have, the 62 elementary schools that we have, and why change the rules in midstream?

[03:44:54] If the decision was made that they would be responsible for the building, why change the rules now in 2025? I do not support changing the rules in midstream. Thank you, Dr. Deans.

[03:45:12] Vice Chair Donohue. Thank you, Madam Chair. I have some conflicted feelings about this issue. Where I grew up, we didn't have charter schools. We just had public schools and we had private schools.

[03:45:30] And I've been a fierce advocate for public education my whole life. I also spoke last week with Supervisor Laura Tocroni how important a school is to its surrounding where we have made prior commitments we cannot go back on those and we own the buildings and I have I'm not familiar with the full list of what proposals Hillsborough or Middleburg have made to ask for renovations for improvements for projects when I toured Middleburg I which was beautiful it's a beautiful facility beautiful

[03:46:06] space. The kids were obviously very happy. The staff was very happy. But I did hear a comment about wanting bigger classroom space, which I understand. But I have a kid in elementary and a kid in middle school. And I was thinking, these classrooms look about as big as all the elementary school classrooms that I've been in and have half the number of students. So to me, that seems like a want not necessarily a need but anyway the to the point of it being a successful experiment you know my understanding of what charter schools are part of what they're supposed to do is give

[03:46:46] space to try out new ideas new techniques new experiments in the way of educating our students and it seems that that has gone well for those two schools I am curious I'm not asking for any information right now but I am curious to get some feedback in the future about what LCPS has if we've had opportunities to look at what they're doing at those schools and see if it can be replicated if their success can be replicated in our public schools which may not be possible

[03:47:21] because again things like student teacher ratio different curriculum the charter schools have more flexibility and autonomy than the rest of the schools in our division. But also to Ms.

[03:47:36] LaBelle's point, the charter schools, yes, they're part of LCPS, but they're not the same as the rest of our public schools. And I think, having heard from the many parents that have come before us, you don't want them to be. That is why you applied to send your kids there, because it's different, right? In some ways, good, and in some ways, maybe not so great. Some of these have already been commented on that the principals there are employees of the board of those schools not of lcps the the charter schools are not required to follow all of lcps's rules and policies they get

[03:48:12] to set your own you all get to set your own curriculum as long as you comply with the state requirements you have a different staff student ratio than what we see in most of our schools and yes it is a lottery but my understanding is that there's also preference given to local residents and siblings of current students which again is not usually how we assign our our students to elementary school zones or other school zones at the rest of our LCPS schools all of which is

[03:48:47] to say I at the end of the day I I think if we're going to have a conversation about does LCPS want to continue the charter school model, then that is a reasonable conversation to have.

[03:49:04] But we have already committed to these charter schools. They exist. We've signed the contracts. They lease space from us. And I don't believe that we can go back on prior commitments to them.

[03:49:21] I'm not saying that I want to obligate LCPS to be on the hook to fund 100% of their proposals, but I'm not comfortable with the staff's original red line of this policy. And for those reasons, I will be voting in support of the proposed amendment.

[03:49:41] I did have a couple of questions or things, again, that I don't need answers now, but I would like to follow up on at some point in the future, and specifically with regard to if either of those buildings have been determined to be historic or if there's been an application for them to be historic buildings.

[03:50:01] And if so, if they were found to be historic preservation buildings, would LCPS or the charter schools be eligible for any grants that could help pay for any renovations? I'm also curious about what the outreach is to various communities, especially underrepresented groups, about their opportunity to apply for these schools.

[03:50:27] Because as has been stated, it is a lottery system that is, my understanding, is open to any students across the county. But I wonder how many of the families of our 80,000 students know that they have this option to apply to. And finally, there is a line in the policy about the charter school's financial documents being reported back to LCPS.

[03:50:51] And I would like to know if those documents are publicly available. Sorry to take up so much time. would you like to answer first just the financial documents we have miss willoughby are you

referencing their annual financial report they are they do fall under our annual auditing process and so they are audited along with our individual schools each year and we do receive that report

[03:51:25] and it's available online thank you I'm going to go with mr. Streffi first since he hasn't spoken and this move in, Ms. Labelle.

[03:51:41] Thank you, Madam Chair. I'm also conflicted. I just wanted to clarify a few points, right, quick sanity check, and that is that we're not voting for funding here on this vote.

[03:51:57] We're not removing schools from the CIP, and they're not currently in the CIP, and I also don't think we are taking responsibility for the building in tonight's vote or any of the buildings in tonight's vote. When it comes to the risk that LCPS may or may not be taken, and the possible need to upgrade the whole building.

[03:52:18] And I see those risks, but we would essentially choose... I'm saying this for clarity, not to give a position at the moment, but we would choose the risk to include or the projects to include in the future.

[03:52:34] And I get the lack of clarity. I think that that's been the biggest issue for me. But I don't know that we inherit risk off the bat. Do we need to take on the risk if we're allowing charters to continue to advocate to be included or specific projects to be included in the CIP?

[03:52:53] And so those are some things I'm thinking about. I do have one question before I kind of finish off my comment. There were some references to, I'm just for clarity, I want to clear the air, Mr. Lewis, if you can help me understand. There were some references to the possibility of no longer funding.

[03:53:13] I heard those phrases, or not continuing to fund, or keeping funding for the charter schools, or removing capital funds, or shifting the burden back to the charter schools. And my understanding is that we have never taken responsibility or funding.

[03:53:31] And even in the cases where we share services, those services are paid from the charter schools back to LCPS. So I just want to clarify that point. Am I missing anything? No, so you're right. At this point, the board has not made promises to do certain things, so we're not removing anything.

[03:53:52] To the point you made when you first started your remarks is we're not adding projects to the CIP or taking them out with this document. So regarding the past history of that, so we have not done any major capital improvements, but we have done a number of capital asset preservation plans out of the cap.

[03:54:14] Mrs. Griffiths mentioned the roof. We did do the roof, but the LCPS paid for that, and so we did not ask for them to pay for that. So there have been a number of CAP projects done at both of the charter schools, and those have been conversations we've had with prior boards and with their approvals to move forward with that, in keeping with the language that has been in the documents since the beginning where the school board would consider things in the CAP.

[03:54:39] And so I'm not sure if I touched on all the points there, But, you know, so we have had some history of that, and I think we've shared that history with the board at different times. And so we're just trying to get some clarity moving forward. Yeah, I appreciate that. So I'll just say, first of all, I acknowledge the dedication of Hillsborough Charter Academy, Middleburg Community Charter School educators, leaders, and parents, and, of course, the scholars.

[03:55:05] Bringing the kids was definitely a cheap shot. But, you know, when these schools were originally established, part of the framework and really the understanding, from my view, was that the

charter school operators would assume responsibilities for the facilities.

[03:55:20] And as has been communicated with us, facilities were the ones the division had previously determined weren't fit to be operated as LCPS schools because of their condition. Right. So I acknowledge that and that the charter operator would take on that responsibility in exchange for the autonomy and flexibility that comes with being a public charter.

[03:55:41] and the responsibility that they would have financially and for the upkeep of the school. Over time, different boards have handled this question differently. The public charter schools were listed as eligible but never actually received funding outside of a few of those projects, which probably created confusion, and I am conflicted about perpetuating potentially that confusion or not giving staff the clarity they need.

[03:56:07] And then when it comes to prioritizing our charters and the CIP, admittedly, I'm not there yet. And to be transparent, my focus and attention has been on the over a dozen of our oldest schools in the division and knowing how much some of these critical systems, refreshes, or overhauls would take from our CIP, even one or two of them, and what a big chunk of the CIP would account for, even like HVAC overhauls or some of these big renovations.

[03:56:38] the limitations of what we can accomplish with respect to our CIP and I acknowledge that many of our most vulnerable students or potentially our highest need schools throughout the county that serve a much higher percentage of those types of students from different demographics and the inequity when compared to some of the newer schools in the county that those schools are the priority for me having said that and having been now open about where I stand in terms of priorities in the CIP.
Hillsborough and Middleburg

[03:57:15] Community Charter are as we've seen thriving with amazing scholars and have become important an important part of the fabric of our educational community and so as someone said we lose nothing by allowing them to ask for help at this point and at this point as I've heard from others I will support the ability for them to have the opportunity to be considered and for the board to continue weigh in and deliberate on the needs of all schools. Yes, Ms. LaBelle. I've spent a lot of

[03:57:52] time with our charter schools recently, so I can answer some of the questions that the board has asked. First of all, the business about being too white. The areas in which these schools are located are in Western Loudoun, as you've pointed out. There is no public school transportation, As I've pointed out, a lot of people in the eastern section of the county would probably love to be able to send their students here, but they find the journey a little bit too far.

[03:58:32] Now, I will also point out that our students in western Loudoun would like to have a little bit more attendance at programs such as our Global Language Institute coming up, which is in dominion but they will be provided with transportation so they will be able to go it's not like the county doesn't stretch or does stretch just if you're going from east to west it's the same distance going from west to east so if transportation were a little bit more available

[03:59:07] for our eastern students they'd probably put their names in as it is both schools are commensurate it with cultural diversity as all the other elementary schools in the West, if you take a look at them. They're all about the same diversity. Middleburg does a little bit better because of the large Asian population over in the Aldi area. Am I correct? Oh, okay.

[03:59:38] All right. But anyway, there's a very large Asian population over in Aldi, which helps Middleburg get a little bit more diverse. Next that I heard was that the contracts that Mr. Lewis was speaking of, they've expired. We negotiated a new contract. The original agreement in section six of the original lease agreement does point out that the leasee shall be responsible at its

[04:00:14] Sole cost and expense for preventative maintenance, general cleanliness, and upkeep, as well as non-capital repairs. The key words here are non-capital. So if you go back and look at all this, yes, they have to keep the building upgraded, working, clean for general maintenance.

[04:00:38] but if it requires capital repairs, such as the HVAC system that will come due in 2028 at a cost of \$1.4 million, it is the board or the school's responsibility to do that.

[04:00:54] They already cover regular maintenance and take very good care of the building, which was not in good repair when they received it. They have done an excellent job in keeping up their end of the bargain. And yes, Mr. Estreffi, we are only asking that you keep the section that says we will consider, not promise, consider any requests by the charter schools to be included in the CIP.

[04:01:28] Thank you. So in reading some of these, well, first of all, Dr. Spence, is there anything in the charter schools that are not in our schools, the programs that they're talking about, the opportunities?

[04:01:49] think you'll see if i mean having visited the schools i mean i think they have what they would consider a dedicated focus for example at middleberg to the arts and then in hands-on learning as you've heard tonight at hca i think you'll see a lot of that across our schools um i think the only thing i would say in response to to a lot of this is i just i don't think it's really healthy to sort of like do this comparative analysis between our charter schools and our other schools because quite frankly we have schools that outperform our charter schools and our charter

[04:02:27] schools outperform some of our schools and a lot of times those things are demographics related and for many other reasons that we've discussed who the students you serve impacts as a constant variable the performance of our schools so I wouldn't compare our charter schools for example to our title one schools I don't think that would be a reasonable thing to do at the end of the day I think our charter schools do well. Clearly the parents and students enjoy their time and experience at the charter schools. I think we heard a great deal of that tonight and we have a number of schools, 100 of them to be exact across Loudoun County, that also do well and

[04:03:02] where our students and parents also enjoy their experiences. So there's in this in their contract it says no joint venture. This agreement shall not be construed as creating a joint venture between the school board and the charter school. The charter school shall be a public school in the school division but shall operate independently subject to the terms of the agreement law and all school board policies regulations rules practices and directives unless waived in writing by the school board where i come from i find the virginia model messy um i come from a place you know coming

[04:03:39] from texas the charter schools are independent they're private they have all sorts of different kinds of funding and they are for-profit some of them others aren't but I find this Virginia model too messy for me to understand what is the where's the boundary but something that really is is something that you know as a school board member that you have to think about is the risks and the risks are safety and funding and LCPS staff recommended closing

[04:04:15] these buildings as they were not viable from a maintenance perspective and needed significant work. And our agreement noted that the buildings did not comply with ADA standards and the building code could require that the entire facility be brought up to current standards if a certain level of work is performed. So in other words, if we start some major improvements, we would be required to retrofit the entire facility, which is not least feasible with significant or complete demolition and rebuild and that's really when we have all these other schools that's kind of hard

[04:04:50] for me to swallow. I may vote for the amendment but I think it's a significant risk and I have to say part of the advocacy of the threat of suing the school board is probably not the smartest move But I am, I may vote, I haven't quite made up my mind yet of how I vote because I do see the beauty in the schools and I do come from small schools and I do think that's important.

[04:05:25] I also think we have to weigh the costs and the benefits. So, okay. Mrs. Griffiths and then. This will be my last question. I had two questions. Can someone tell me, the recovery school, how much we spent on that and how many we have enrolled, how many students?

[04:05:47] Number one. Number two, please clarify the roof at Hillsborough. When I was there, I was told that you guys, the LCPS came in and fixed it, but then billed them afterwards and they had to pay for it.

[04:06:06] They had to fundraise to pay for it. So, first question, I'd like to know how much we, and just for everybody here, let them know how much we spent on the recovery school, how many are enrolled there, how many students currently, and explain, you know, and just clarify the roof, because maybe I had a different understanding.

[04:06:29] Dr. Spence and I were talking about it just previously. Thank you. Thank you, Ms. Griffiths. So, I will have to get back to you on the cost of the recovery school, because I don't have that with me. Regarding the roof, when you mentioned the replacement for a new roof, we did replace the roof at Middleburg, and that was done through the cap and was not asked to be reimbursed.

[04:06:51] We did do some repairs at Hillsborough, which they did pay for, and that's in keeping with our maintenance agreements. Each year, the school board approves and updates the service agreements, both with support services and with DDI, for miscellaneous work that's done.

[04:07:07] So the repairs that were done at the Hillsborough roof were part of that maintenance agreement and were paid for. But the roof replacement, and that's what I thought you were referring to, the whole new roof, was done at Middleburg at no cost to the school. No, I was talking about Hillsborough. Off the top of my head, the recovery school, if I remember correctly, over 400,000, three students.

[04:07:29] Thank you. Yes, Vice Chair Donahue. Thank you, Madam Chair. I call the question. Can you retract it?

[04:07:47] Sure. I don't think there's any more discussion to be had, I'm assuming, but I don't see any more. Okay, so we'll go ahead and vote on Ms. Chernoff's amendment.

[04:08:04] Ms. Chernoff, would you please remind us of what it is? Sorry. Yes. On the red line version, replace lines 285 and 286 with the following language. A charter school facility or campus will not be included in the school board's capital improvement program, which includes the Capital Asset Preservation Program for current or future capital improvements, unless the school board deems it necessary to do so.

[04:08:30] In addition, the school board will defer to current charter agreements for existing charter schools. Okay, so then this other part, but we'll revise all future renewal charter agreements and leases to reflect language consistent with this policy.

[04:08:50] That's not part of it. Okay. So this also means that we can, that future renewal charter agreements can be changed, correct?

[04:09:08] What? Okay. So seeing that we've, no. Okay.

[04:09:32] Let's go ahead and vote. Board members, let me get my screen. So I'm properly moved and seconded. Board member, clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote.

[04:09:51] - Yeah, we're voting for the amendment. And then after this, we have to vote to amend the base motion. Okay, Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote? - No. - Okay, clerk, please close and display the vote.

[04:10:08] That motion passes with seven to two with Dr. Deans and Ms. Chandler in opposition of the vote. We'll go ahead and vote on the motion as amended, the base motion as amended. Is there any discussion?

[04:10:24] Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. What did I say? Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote again? No. She said no.

[04:10:41] Clerk, please close and display the vote. That motion passes, 7-2, with Ms. Chandler and Dr. Deans absent in opposition of the vote. Okay, we are going to move on. And no clapping, please. We've established that. This is what you do.

[04:10:56] Okay, we are now moving on to information item 11.01. Oh, we've moved on to 11.02, Office of the Auditor General, FY26, audit plan presented by Ahmaud Woods, Auditor General.

[04:11:14] Mr. Woods, please keep it down because we are going to have to continue the school board meeting. Thank you.

[04:11:45] Mr. Woods. Good evening, Chair Mansfield, Vice Chair Donahue, members of the board.

[04:12:06] I'm here to present the fiscal year 2026 audit plan for the Office of the Auditor General. For fiscal year 26, we have five audits approved. They include governance, effectiveness, and risk mitigation review, health, safety, and crisis response, comprehensive staffing strategy and process efficiency audit, facilities equity and infrastructure maintenance audit, professional learning and development effectiveness review.

[04:12:43] And just to give you a little background on how these audits were developed, first we identified audit topics by surveying school principals, senior staff, board members, and cabinet.

[04:12:59] We then considered and prioritized those audit topics by compliance, financial, reputational, safety, and operational risks, frequency of audits, and prior audit issues. During the FY26 planning, we developed a universe of potential audit engagements based on those surveys and risk prioritations or risk areas. We then presented the audit universe to the legislative audit and policy committee for review, selection, and ultimately the approval. And that is what I

[04:13:39] am presenting to you all tonight. Welcome to take any one of your questions. board members do you have any questions no yes we don't have no thank you so much mr woods um short and sweet um

are you sure you don't have any questions anyone okay thank you very much

[04:14:13] um and i look forward to those uh okay the next one is miss chandler uh 11.03 joint committee of the louden county school board and louden county board of supervisors addition to the 2025-2026 work plan and i have asked ms chandler to do it since she served as the vice co-chair because i was out thank you madam chair um the joint committee work plan is was established on april

[04:14:42] 24th 2025 um at our last i'm excuse me um at the september 15th 2025 meeting of the joint committee of the school board and the board of supervisors supervisor glass introduced and the committee voted four to zero to two with two absent for the vote to recommend to both boards that we approve the addition of an information item concerning the lcps lcso lpd memorandum of understanding

[04:15:16] to the 2025-2026 joint committee work plan and direct lcps and county staff to prepare a board of supervisors and school board approved item for our november meeting this addition to the work plan would reflect some consistency with how the process was developed as this was also historically an item before the joint committee on april 17th 2023 unless other unless directed otherwise this item will return to the school board for an action item on october 14 2025.

[04:15:51] any questions or discussion um could we uh i guess it could go to consent can i get a thumbs up for the consent keeping item um vice chair do you have a question vice chair donahue has a question sorry thank you madam chair um my my only slight hesitation was that this proposal

[04:16:23] to delete this policy has not been put forward for public feedback um it it may be moot because As Ms. Chandler noted, essentially the content of this policy has been absorbed into 2310, rendering 2320 likely unnecessary.

[04:16:45] I just have a small amount of hesitation because it hasn't been sent out for public feedback. Maybe we should ask Mr. Allen, is it necessary if it's in another policy to go ahead and get public feedback?

[04:17:01] would that cut square corners as you like to say thank you chair mansfeld it's within the board's purview to send it out for um feedback if it would like to do so but it's also within the board's discretion um not to do so given the posture of um the feedback that was solicited as part of 2310 um so all that's to say it's discretionary okay so um board members thumbs up

[04:17:33] whether you want to send it out or yeah send it out or okay so how about go to consent do you know what we're talking about okay you know that it's in it's in it's in another policy okay and it's

[04:18:07] not 2310 it's 2320 okay it will go for action next time all right so we'll continue with item 12 closed meeting vice chair donahue do you have a motion yes thank you madam chair i move that the Loudoun County School Board recess this public meeting and enter into a closed meeting pursuant to section 2.2-3712 of the Code of Virginia for the following. Consultation with legal counsel pertaining to actual litigation concerning a national opioid settlement with eight secondary

[04:18:47] opioid manufacturers requiring the provision of legal advice by such counsel and where such consultation or briefing in open meeting would adversely affect the negotiating or litigating posture of the public body as authorized by section 2.2-3711 sub a sub 7 of the Code of Virginia and consultation with legal counsel and briefings by staff members or consultants pertaining to actual or probable litigation where such consultation or briefing in open meeting would adversely affect the negotiating or litigating posture of the public body as authorized by section 2.2-3711 sub-A sub-7 of the Code of Virginia and

consultation with legal counsel employed or retained by a public body regarding a specific legal matter requiring

[04:19:23] the provision of legal advice by such counsel as authorized by section 2.2-3711 sub-A sub-8 of the code of Virginia and discussion or consideration of disciplinary matters or any other matters that would involve the disclosure of information contained in a scholastic record concerning LCPS students as authorized by section 2.2-3711 sub a sub 2. Vice chair Donahue has made a motion do I have a second second I have a second by Mr. Estreffi it's improperly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board go into closed session is there any discussion seeing none

[04:19:58] clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote dr. deans would you please state your vote yes okay mr. astreffi would you please vote clerk please close and display the vote and

[04:20:25] that motion passes unanimously the board is now in closed session thank you the board is now coming

[04:51:03] out of session sorry didn't mean for it to be that loud um vice chair donahue do you have a motion yes thank you madam chair i move that the closed meeting be adjourned that the loudon county school board reconvene its public meeting and that the minutes of the public meeting reflect that no formal action was taken in the closed meeting i have a motion by vice chair donahue do i have a second second i have a second by miss chandler been properly moved and seconded is there any discussion seeing none we will go ahead and oh there you are okay uh we'll go ahead and vote

[04:51:40] clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote dr deans would you please state your vote yes clerk please close and display the vote that motion passes unanimously vice chair donahue do you have another motion yes please thank you madam chair i move that the following resolution certifying the closed meeting be adopted and reflected in the minutes of this public meeting resolution number one one dash two four slash two excuse me resolution number one one dash two five slash two six whereas the laden county school board has convened a public meeting on this date pursuant to an affirmative recorded vote and in accordance with the provisions of the

[04:52:19] Virginia Freedom of Information Act and whereas section 2.2-3712 sub d of the Code of Virginia requires a certification by the school board that such closed meeting was conducted in conformity with Virginia law now therefore be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board hereby certifies that to the best of each member's knowledge one only public business matters lawfully exempted from open meeting requirements by Virginia law were discussed in the closed meeting to which the certification applies and two only such public business matters as were identified in the motion convening the closed meeting were heard, discussed, or considered by the Loudoun County School Board. I have a motion by Vice Chair Donahue. Do you have a second?

[04:52:54] I have a second by Mr. Estreffi. Do we have any discussion? Seeing none, we'll go ahead and take the vote. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote? Yes. Clerk, would you please close and display the vote?

[04:53:16] That motion passes unanimously. Vice Chair Donahue, do you have another motion? Yes, thank you, Madam Chair. I move that the Loudoun County School Board approve the attached resolution to participate in the proposed settlement of opioid-related claims against eight opioid manufacturers, Alvagen, Amnil, Apotex, Hikma, Indivior, Mylan, Sun, and Zytus, and their related corporate entities, and

directs the board chair to execute the documents necessary to effectuate participation in the settlements, including the required release of claims against settling

[04:53:54] entities i have a motion do i have a second i have a second by dr rasheed is there any discussion saying none we'll take an electronic vote clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote dr deans would you please state your vote yes clerk please close and display the vote and that motion passes unanimously vice chair donahue you have another motion yes thank you madam chair last one i move that the levin county school board authorized council for the school

[04:54:31] board to proceed in the manner outlined in the closed session. I have a motion by Vice Chair Donahue. Do I have a second? I have a second by Ms. Chandler. Is there any discussion? Seeing no discussion. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Dr. Deans, would you please state your vote? Yes. Clerk, please close and display the vote. That motion

[04:55:02] passes 7-2 with Ms. Chernoff and Ms. LaBelle. Mr. Allen, do I need to re-vote? Do we clear the board and do we re-vote or what just go ahead and clear the board okay uh mrs griffiths do you know what we're voting on now okay clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote

[04:55:37] dr deans would you please state your vote yes um what did i oh clerk please close and display the vote that motion passes 63 with mrs griffiths ms chernoff and ms la belle uh in opposition of the vote so we'll move on to i think that's all right um we'll move on to item 13 board member comment and committee reports i propose that we move on from them because can i have a thumbs up to move

[04:56:13] on okay all right and then we'll now move on to new business board members do we have any more new business thanks dr deans yes miss labelle yes i'm very concerned because a letter went out earlier this week from one of our schools stating that we had already voted on one of our proclamations it was we found out later something that was put out last year but we hadn't voted on that particular proclamation yet I am concerned that a

[04:56:49] lot of the things that are put out we use electronic signatures and I would like to suggest that anything that requires our signatures we should sign here at the board there's so much fraud going on out there anything could happen happens so to protect ourselves I think it's important that we sign things like we do in committee right there at the time of action so if we could discuss that and perhaps come up to consensus on that that would be helpful I checked with mr. Allen and he said that that's how we need to deal with this it's not

[04:57:28] a policy unless we want to make it one okay so then we would have an information item about this to discuss it mr. Allen oh he has to go get his mic I think he said we could do it either way but I'll wait check he comes back thank you chairman so yes if the board wanted to further discuss this tonight as a new business item it could to discuss if it wants to take up a norm

[04:58:07] that's recommended by miss LaBelle or to the extent the board doesn't have an appetite to discuss it tonight, Ms. LaBelle could bring it forth as a discussion slash information item at a future meeting. Again, it's not an action item. You don't need to take a vote because this is a norm that the board would have. It's not part of a policy. But in order for Ms.

[04:58:30] LaBelle to bring it forth as an information or discussion item discreetly on a future board agenda pursuant to policy, she would need two of her colleagues to endorse that. Vice Chair Donahue. Thank you, Madam Chair. I was wondering if anyone here has the exact language of what this email

allegedly said. Ms. LaBelle indicated that it was an assertion that the board had already voted on the proclamation. No, no. So I would like to hear from someone if they have the exact language in

[04:59:10] front of them. If I may, I believe it was the proclamation from last year. Yes. It was not. You need to wait until you're called upon. So let's ask first, Vice Chair Donahue's question was first, and then you can raise your hand and I'll get to you.

[04:59:31] I thought Dr. Spence might have that information. Dr. Spence, do you have that information? It wasn't specifically clear that it was the 2025 proclamation they were referring to, but it wasn't clear that it wasn't.

[04:59:49] Best I can offer you, I think that it appears to have been premature, and that's something that we did discuss at the administrative level. Ms. LeBell.

[05:00:05] I went back after I got the first comment from one of my constituents and looked at it. It was the proclamation from 2024 and it specifically stated that it covered the month of October from October 1st to October 31st.

[05:00:26] So it was last year's proclamation. Yes, Vice Chair Donahue. Thank you, Madam Chair. I'm confused.

[05:00:42] If Ms. LaBelle is asserting that a teacher sent out a quote from a proclamation that this board approved i fail to see what is problematic about that uh even if it is a quote from this current year's proclamation that document was put up on board docs as an item that was going to be discussed and voted on at this meeting tonight i again i if if a teacher said this or a principal said this is an item that is coming up for consideration before the board I don't see what is problematic about that.

[05:01:19] That was not something they said coming up before the board. It was presented as a done deal. But my concern, excuse me, my concern is that signatures now really should be by hand, in person, by us, rather than put on documents going forward electronically.

[05:01:44] I don't think they should be put on electronically. I think we should sign them ourselves, as we do in committee. That was my concern. This brought it all up, but yes, what I'm concerned about is our signatures, making sure that it is us that is signing documents, not somebody who puts something out online that may be deceptive.

[05:02:15] Yes, Ms. Chandler. Thank you. Mr. Allen, is it the vote that validates the proclamation or the signature? it's the vote it's memorialized by the signature is how i would characterize it so in terms of the mechanism the the most important piece is the vote which would be on record and captured on record in multiple places that's correct and my understanding is that somebody doesn't vote for it their signature is not on there because i've seen some proclamations where mrs griffith's

[05:02:53] signature is not there because she abstains for all of them and if yeah if you miss consent your name doesn't go on there. Yes, Mr. Estreffi. Thank you, Madam Chair. I appreciate the conversation.

[05:03:16] Regardless of what the discussion is about proclamation or a message going on, I think that's kind of an operational discussion. I'm having trouble tying that to whether a digital signature is of concern or not, and I'm hesitant to have a conversation about removing that as a tool in the toolbox, because I know it's prevalent in use, and I get maybe some generic security concerns about it, but I think it's just

common practice, and I don't, absent any other reason, like, you know, incident or reason, I would probably not support it. Yeah, I don't know that I would

[05:03:53] support it either at this point, because there's a lot of things that, well, for instance, there were a lot of graduation certificates that we, that I signed, that I didn't have to sign by hand, and it was all digital. So anybody else? Yes, Mrs. Griffiths. Thank you, Madam Chair. I apologize for jumping in before. I guess the question is, the proclamation you're referencing was from last year. So did you sign it? I guess that's the question. It was legitimate, right? I don't know

[05:04:30] that we have to go through this. I think the thing is, is that if you voted on it, that was if you voted on it then you signed it right it sounds like the thing that makes it legitimate is the vote and whether or not your signature is on the paper is irrelevant and that's a personal choice and if the proclamation was passed last october it was effectively still in place until

[05:05:05] we made another proclamation tonight which passed so i i don't feel that it's necessary to spend time on this i i think the process works as it is so if we're going to establish a norm can i get a thumbs up. I have one more thing to say. Yes ma'am. Going forward I think the problem is that so many things are lumped in on the consent agenda that if you are disagreeing with one item but really want one or two others you have to either decide to say yes to the whole thing or no to the whole

[05:05:41] thing. I think that going forward if we're going to present proclamations they could be done one at a time no if it's on consent and you vote you're voting for all of consent regardless you're not doing if you want to take something out then you take it out like miss griffiths today she took it out because she didn't want to vote for it she also then and we put it into action that's the way that's the way it is that's the way consent goes um i don't think that so i'm confused by the whole

[05:06:18] thing um so i don't i don't know that all the board members have to sign off on all the proclamations you could have the chair do so on behalf of the board that is an option because it was voted on unanimously but i think honestly they're not on i think if they didn't vote for it and they're not on consent they their names aren't on there they're not yeah miss don Vice Chair Donoghue.

[05:06:54] Thank you, Madam Chair. We discussed this with Ms. Byrne, my team, because I got some constituent inquiries about why my name, why my signature was not on some proclamations that were previously approved by this board in light of, they were on issues that my constituents thought that I would have been in support of.

[05:07:17] And in my conversations with Ms. Byrne, My understanding is that she has digital copies of the signatures of every one of the nine of us. And if we vote in favor of the consent agenda, she applies the digital signature of the members who vote in favor of the consent agenda on the proclamations.

[05:07:39] So if you abstain or you vote against, your name doesn't go on there. Or if you're like me and sometimes you get here after we've already voted on consent, my name does not go on those. Even if I wanted to support them, my name is not on it. So I don't think that there's an issue here.

[05:07:58] It's only the names of the board members who are actively supporting these measures anyway. If there needs to be a discussion about security measures related to digital signatures for items that are of greater significance and consequence, that is certainly a conversation that I would imagine we could have another day.

[05:08:18] okay so i'm hearing that there might not be well is there any agreement to have further discussion on this or do we feel no okay no thanks okay dr deans do you feel you need more discussion on this no ma'am no okay okay so with that um we will move on to adjournment is if there's no more further business the september 30th 2025 loudon county school board meeting is now adjourned please drive safely home



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